

Lecture 02: Visual Information Design

COMS 4170 □ Spring 2026

Prof. Celeste Layne
Tuesday January 20, 2026



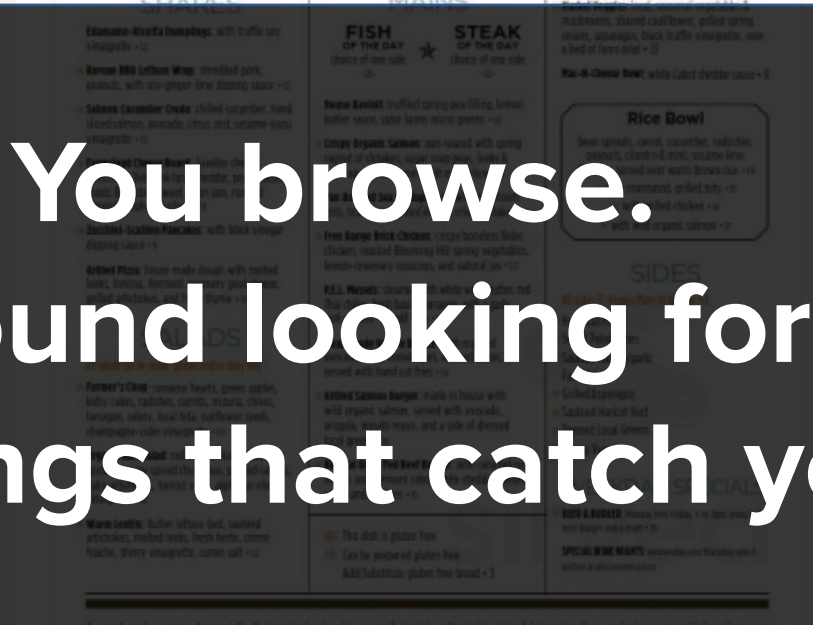
COMS 4170 · SPRING 2026

Visual Information Design





Your eyes skip around looking for relevant or interesting things that catch your eye.



You want to buy a guitar. Where might you look?



craigslist

post to classifieds
my account

search craigslist
search

event calendar

M	T	W	T	F	S	S
15	16	17	18	19	20	21
22	23	24	25	26	27	28
29	30	31	1	2	3	4
5	6	7	8	9	10	11

help, faq, abuse, legal
avoid scams & fraud
personal safety tips
terms of use new
privacy policy
system status

about craigslist
craigslist is hiring in sf
craigslist open source
craigslist blog
best-of-craigslist
craigslist TV
"craigslist joe"
craig connects
progressive directory
weather quake tide

SF bay area sfc sby eby pen nby scz

community

- activities
- artists
- childcare
- classes
- events
- general
- groups
- local news
- lost+found
- musicians
- pets
- politics
- rideshare
- volunteers

personals

- strictly platonic
- women seek women
- women seeking men
- men seeking women
- men seeking men
- misc romance
- casual encounters
- missed connections
- rants and raves

discussion forums

apple	help	photo
arts	history	p.o.c.
atheist	housing	politics
autos	jobs	psych
beauty	jokes	queer
bikes	kink	recover
celebs	legal	religion
comp	linux	romance
crafts	m4m	science
diet	manners	spirit
divorce	marriage	sports
dying	media	tax
eco	money	travel
educ	motocy	tv
feedbk	music	vegan
film	nonprofit	w4w
fitness	open	wed
fixit	outdoor	wine
food	over 50	women
frugal	parent	words

housing

- apts / housing
- housing swap
- housing wanted
- office / commercial
- parking / storage
- real estate for sale
- rooms / shared
- rooms wanted
- sublets / temporary
- vacation rentals

for sale

antiques	free
appliances	furniture
arts+crafts	garage sale
atv/utv/sno	general
auto parts	heavy equip
baby+kid	household
barter	jewelry
beauty+hlth	materials
bikes	motorcycles
boats	music instr
books	photo+video
business	rvs+camp
cars+trucks	sporting
cds/dvd/vhs	tickets
cell phones	tools
clothes+acc	toys+games
collectibles	trailers
computers	video gaming
electronics	wanted
farm+garden	

services

automotive	legal
beauty	lessons
cell/mobile	marine
computer	pet
creative	real estate

jobs

- accounting+finance
- admin / office
- arch / engineering
- art / media / design
- biotech / science
- business / mgmt
- customer service
- education
- food / bev / hosp
- general labor
- government
- human resources
- internet engineers
- legal / paralegal
- manufacturing
- marketing / pr / ad
- medical / health
- nonprofit sector
- real estate
- retail / wholesale
- sales / biz dev
- salon / spa / fitness
- security
- skilled trade / craft
- software / qa / dba
- systems / network
- technical support
- transport
- tv / film / video
- web / info design
- writing / editing
- [ETC]
- [part-time]

gigs

computer	event
creative	labor
crew	talent
domestic	writing

nearby cl

- bakersfield
- chico
- fresno
- gold country
- hanford
- humboldt
- inland empire
- klamath falls
- las vegas
- los angeles
- medford
- mendocino co
- merced
- modesto
- monterey
- orange co
- palm springs
- redding
- reno
- roseburg
- sacramento
- san luis obispo
- santa barbara
- santa maria
- siskiyou co
- stockton
- susanville
- ventura
- visalia-tulare
- yuba-sutter

us cities

us states

canada

cl worldwide

The "For sale" group seems relevant

"Music instr" subgroup seems relevant



Information hierarchy guides attention at a high level

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my account

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eby

pen

nby

scz

community

activities

artists

childcare

classes

events

general

groups

local news

lost+found

musicians

pets

politics

rideshare

volunteers

personals

strictly platonic

women seek women

women seeking men

men seeking women

men seeking men

misc romance

casual encounters

missed connections

rants and raves

discussion forums

apple

arts

atheist

autos

beauty

bikes

celebs

comp

crafts

diet

divorce

dying

eco

educ

feedbk

film

fitness

fixit

food

frugal

help

history

housing

jobs

jokes

kink

legal

linux

m4m

manners

marriage

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motocy

music

nonprofit

open

outdoor

over 50

parent

photo

p.o.c.

politics

psych

queer

recover

religion

romance

science

spirit

sports

tax

travel

tv

vegan

w4w

wed

wine

women

words

housing

apts / housing

housing swap

housing wanted

office / commercial

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real estate for sale

rooms / shared

rooms wanted

sublets / temporary

vacation rentals

for sale

antiques

appliances

arts+crafts

atv/utv/sno

auto parts

baby+kid

barter

beauty+hlth

bikes

boats

books

business

cars+trucks

cds/dvd/vhs

cell phones

clothes+acc

collectibles

computers

electronics

farm+garden

free

furniture

garage sale

general

heavy equip

household

jewelry

materials

motorcycles

music instr

photo+video

rvs+camp

sporting

tickets

tools

toys+games

trailers

video gaming

wanted

services

automotive

beauty

cell/mobile

computer

creative

legal

lessons

marine

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real estate

jobs

accounting+finance

admin / office

arch / engineering

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customer service

education

food / bev / hosp

general labor

government

human resources

internet engineers

legal / paralegal

manufacturing

marketing / pr / ad

medical / health

nonprofit sector

real estate

retail / wholesale

sales / biz dev

salon / spa / fitness

security

skilled trade / craft

software / qa / dba

systems / network

technical support

transport

tv / film / video

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writing

nearby cl

bakersfield

chico

fresno

gold country

hanford

humboldt

inland empire

klamath falls

las vegas

los angeles

medford

mendocino co

merced

modesto

monterey

orange co

palm springs

redding

reno

roseburg

sacramento

san luis obispo

santa barbara

santa maria

siskiyou co

stockton

susanville

ventura

visalia-tulare

yuba-sutter

us cities

us states

canada

cl worldwide

...to help users find relevant information.





**The way you display that information
dictates what people will pay most
attention to.**



The main feature of many websites is to display information in a way that helps users accomplish a goal.



```
i:Exit -:PrevPg <Space>:NextPg v:View Attachm. d:Del r:Reply j:Next ?:Help
624 Aug 03 T Martinez ( 37) Loans with tiny points are here now
625 0 Jul 01 R. Jackson ( 123) Loans with tiny rates are here now
626 Aug 05 Benjamin E. Mag ( 50) Long time no hear
627 May 17 Krista Aaron ( 44) long time no see....
628 0 Jun 03 Josiah House ( 35) Looking for a hot date tonight, tomorrow, or next week?
629 Jul 03 Brigitte I. Hay ( 63) Looking for a New H.0me?
630 May 17 Joe Burns ( 58) Looking for you
631 Jun 01 Save in a poor ( 145) Low Rate Consolidation Mortgage Loan
632 + Jul 02 Igiel@virtualig ( 2) LowCost SoftWare OnCD
--Mutt: Mail/junk/spam [Msgs:950 Old:142 10M]--(subject/date)-- (66%)
Date: Mon, 17 May 2004 03:40:09 +0100
From: Krista Aaron <Christinefeminine@highstream.com>
Subject: long time no see....

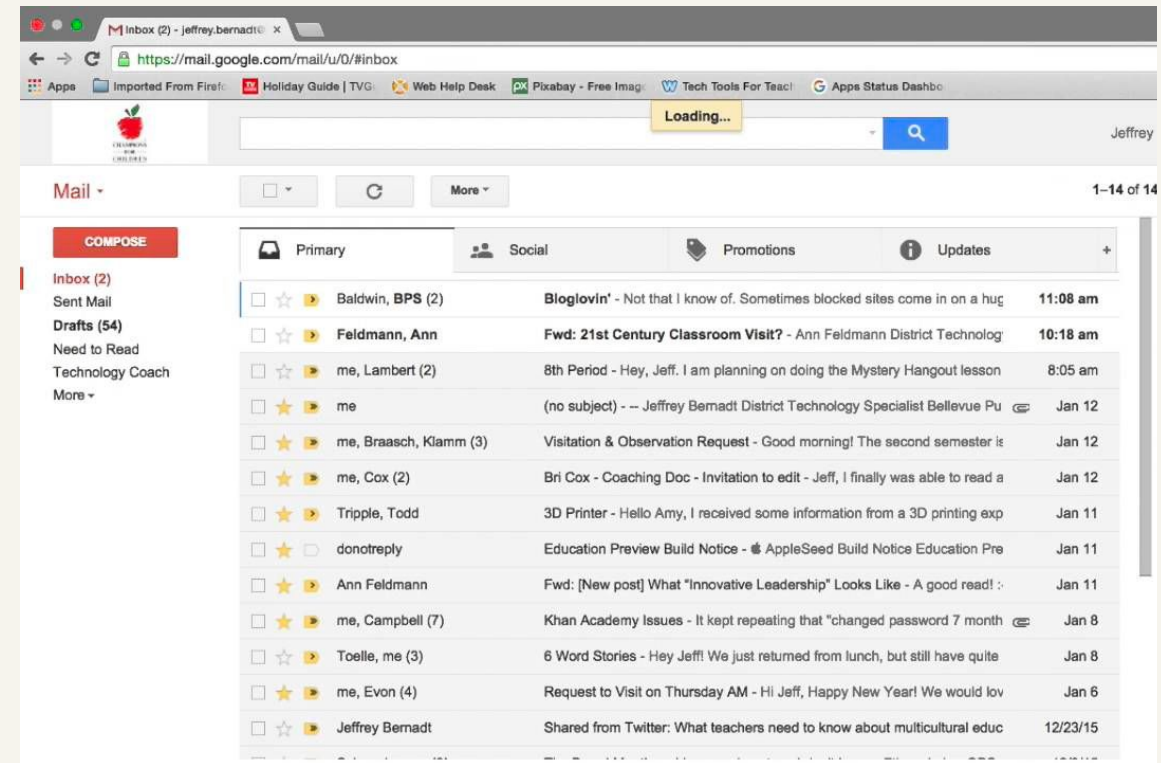
[-- Autoview using /usr/bin/elinks -force-html -dump '/tmp/mutt.html' --]
My name is Jen and I'm new to this dating thing. I've checked out your profile
you put up and it's interesting. => I just want to get to know you a little
better if you don't mind, come check my profile out at:

www.live.jen.com/chat.html

I also got a webcam so we can make it interesting, anyways hope you get back to
me.
bye :)

gxsnnxxgnduvy.jwyceudc.jobxs
zcozcrociesbehgbpow
rnxlfu.jnqpbllpdkgwyoofracsz
xmqaubxsbjrppoibvlpfhqowldtp
bixhghvrxtggfeocofzybc
hugzffaffulsklpzhrfxbtt
btpztlfotqmmoiuulosqv
-- 627/950: Krista Aaron long time no see.... -- (69%)
Key is not bound. Press '?' for help.
```

Pine text-based email client, 1989



GMail free email service, 2004



Let's look at examples

1. What is the users' main goal?
2. What information is displayed to help the user achieve that goal?

Ignore the interaction and focus on the information being displayed.



What is the users
main goal?

What information
helps the user achieve
that goal?

Ignore the interaction and focus on the
information being displayed.

The screenshot displays the Amazon Books homepage. At the top, the Amazon Prime logo is on the left, and a search bar with a magnifying glass icon is on the right. Below the search bar, a navigation bar includes links for Departments, Browsing History, Lydia's Amazon.com, Today's Deals, Gift Cards, Registry, Sell, and Help. A secondary navigation bar lists categories: Books, Advanced Search, New Releases, Amazon Charts, Best Sellers & More, The New York Times® Best Sellers, Children's Books, Textbooks, Textbook Rentals, and Sell U.

The main content area is divided into several sections:

- Popular in Books:** A list of categories including Award Winners, Bargain Books, Best Books of the Month, Best Books of 2017, Books in Spanish, Children's Books, Deals in Books, and Top 20 Lists in Books.
- More in Books:** A list of categories including 100 Books to Read in a Lifetime, Amazon Book Review Blog, Amazon Books on Facebook, Amazon Books on Twitter, and Amazon First Reads.
- Amazon Kindle:** A list of categories including Kindle eBooks, Kindle Deals, Kindle Unlimited, Prime Reading, and Spanish Kindle eBooks.
- Textbooks:** A list of categories including Textbooks Store, Textbook Rentals, Sell Us Your Books, and Kindle eTextbooks.

The central part of the page features a carousel of book covers with a left arrow button. The books shown are:

- The Craft of Research, Third Edition** by Wayne C. Booth, Gregory G. Colomb, and Joseph M. Williams. It has a 4.5-star rating and 384 reviews.
- A Manual for Writers of Research Papers, Theses, and Dissertations** by Kate L. Turabian and Wayne C. Booth. It is the 7th Edition, has a 4.5-star rating and 753 reviews, and is available as a paperback.
- Academic Writing for Graduate Students** by John M. Swales and Christine B. Feak. It is the 3rd Edition, has a 4.5-star rating and 128 reviews, and is available as a paperback for \$25.65 with Prime.

Below the carousel, there are three more sections:

- More from the Amazon Book Editors:** A section with a grid of author portraits.
- Best Books of the Month Top 10:** A section featuring a book cover and a list of categories: Literature & Fiction, Kids & Teens Books, Mystery & Thriller, and a link to See all categories.
- Celebrity Picks 2017:** A section featuring a grid of author portraits and a list of names: Sheryl Sandberg, John Green, Gabrielle Union, and Denis Leary, with a link to See all Celebrity Picks.
- Best Books of 2017 Top 100 Print Books:** A section featuring a book cover and a list of categories: Fiction, Children's Books, Biographies & Memoirs, and a link to See all.

What is the users main goal?

What information helps the user achieve that goal?

Ignore the interaction and focus on the information being displayed.



columbia



All

Maps

Images

News

Shopping

More

Settings

Tools

About 647,000,000 results (0.66 seconds)

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[Ad] www.columbia.com/ ▼

Save at the Official **Columbia** Site. Free Shipping & More for Members!

Types: Jackets, Vests, Shirts, Pants, Shorts, Footwear, Accessories, Backpacks

35% Off Select Styles · Columbia Apparel & Gear · Waterproof Puffy Jackets · Columbia Gift Cards

Columbia Sportswear: Outdoor Clothing, Outerwear & Accessories

<https://www.columbia.com/> ▼

Shop direct from **Columbia** Sportswear. Our Outerwear is Tested Tough in the Pacific Northwest. Shop for Jackets, Pants, Shirts, Shoes & more.

[Men](#) · [Women](#) · [Insulated & Down](#) · [Jackets](#)

Columbia University in the City of New York

<https://www.columbia.edu/> ▼

Schedule a tour of the Morningside campus. Five graduates in cap and gown celebrate facing the camera. Commencement. University-wide commencement information. Annette Lopes smiling at camera. Employment. Careers at **Columbia**. College walk in front of Low Library. **Columbia** Data. A statistical snapshot of the ...

[Centers and Institutes](#) · [Students](#) · [Manage My UNI](#) · [Careers at Columbia](#)

Columbia University Libraries: Libraries Home

library.columbia.edu/ ▼

Through the launch of a Shared Collection Service developed in partnership with Princeton University Library and The New York Public Library, **Columbia** added over seven million items to its catalog this month... Staff Profile: Ben Armintor Ben Armintor discusses his role in open source software for libraries, his journey ...

You've visited this page 4 times. Last visit: 1/16/18

Columbia - Wikipedia

<https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Columbia> ▼

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What information helps the user achieve that goal?

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discussion forums

apple

arts

atheist

autos

beauty

bikes

celebs

comp

crafts

diet

divorce

dying

eco

educ

feedbk

film

fitness

fixit

food

frugal

help

history

housing

jobs

jokes

kink

legal

linux

m4m

manners

marriage

media

money

motocy

music

nonprofit

open

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over 50

parent

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politics

psych

queer

recover

religion

romance

science

spirit

sports

tax

travel

tv

vegan

w4w

wed

wine

women

words

housing

apts / housing

housing swap

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vacation rentals

for sale

antiques

appliances

arts+crafts

atv/utv/sno

auto parts

baby+kid

barter

beauty+hlth

bikes

boats

books

business

cars+trucks

cds/dvd/vhs

cell phones

clothes+acc

collectibles

computers

electronics

farm+garden

free

furniture

garage sale

general

heavy equip

household

jewelry

materials

motorcycles

music instr

photo+video

rvs+camp

sporting

tickets

tools

toys+games

trailers

video gaming

wanted

services

automotive

beauty

cell/mobile

computer

creative

legal

lessons

marine

pet

real estate

jobs

accounting+finance

admin / office

arch / engineering

art / media / design

biotech / science

business / mgmt

customer service

education

food / bev / hosp

general labor

government

human resources

internet engineers

legal / paralegal

manufacturing

marketing / pr / ad

medical / health

nonprofit sector

real estate

retail / wholesale

sales / biz dev

salon / spa / fitness

security

skilled trade / craft

software / qa / dba

systems / network

technical support

transport

tv / film / video

web / info design

writing / editing

[ETC]

[part-time]

gigs

computer

creative

crew

domestic

event

labor

talent

writing



How should we design information to suit the needs and abilities of users?



Here is some undifferentiated text



You are cordially invited to Robert and Alexandra's delectable after dinner party. Wine and nibbles will be served. When: February 20th, 2019 at 9:30PM. Where: The pad. Holla if you need directions. Kindly let us know if you will be attending by February 1st.



Step 1.



Group related information into chunks

You are cordially invited to Robert and Alexandra's delectable after dinner party. Wine and nibbles will be served. When: February 20th, 2018 at 9:30PM. Where: The pad. Holla if you need directions. Kindly let us know if you will be attending by February 1st.

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Step 2.



In each chunk, decide what's important to emphasize.

You are cordially invited to
Robert and Alexandra's delectable after
dinner party.

You are cordially invited to

**Robert and Alexandra's
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Step 3.

Consolidate into three groups



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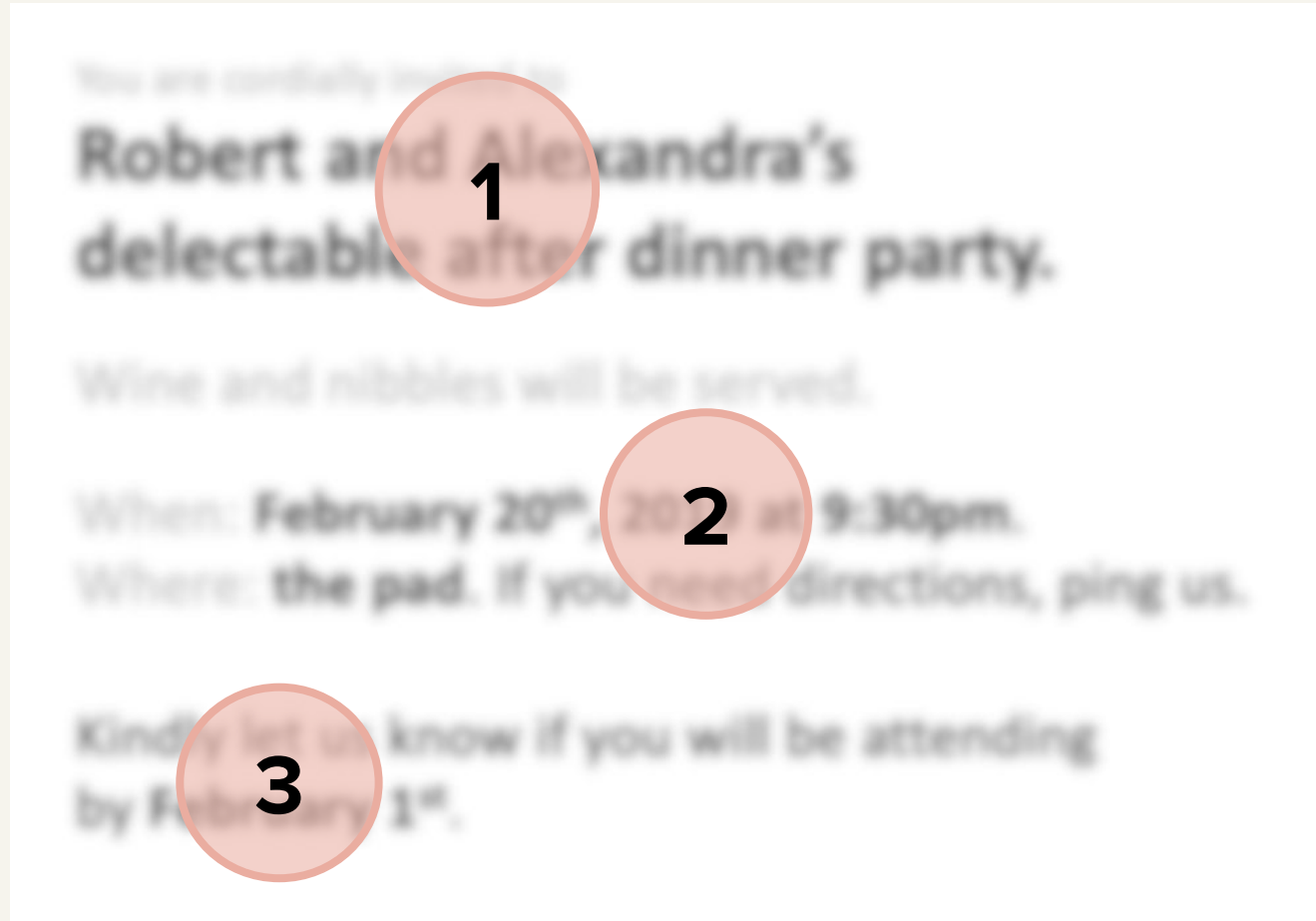
When: **February 20th, 2019 at 9:30pm.**

Where: **The pad.** Holla if you need directions.

Kindly let us know if you will be attending
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Use the squint test to verify the Hierarchy of Information



Users can't focus on everything at once. They have a spotlight of attention.



A visual hierarchy of information allows designers to guide users' attention.



COMS 4170 · SPRING 2026

7 Tools for Visually Conveying Importance



1. Conceptual Grouping:

A few high-level visual groups (3)



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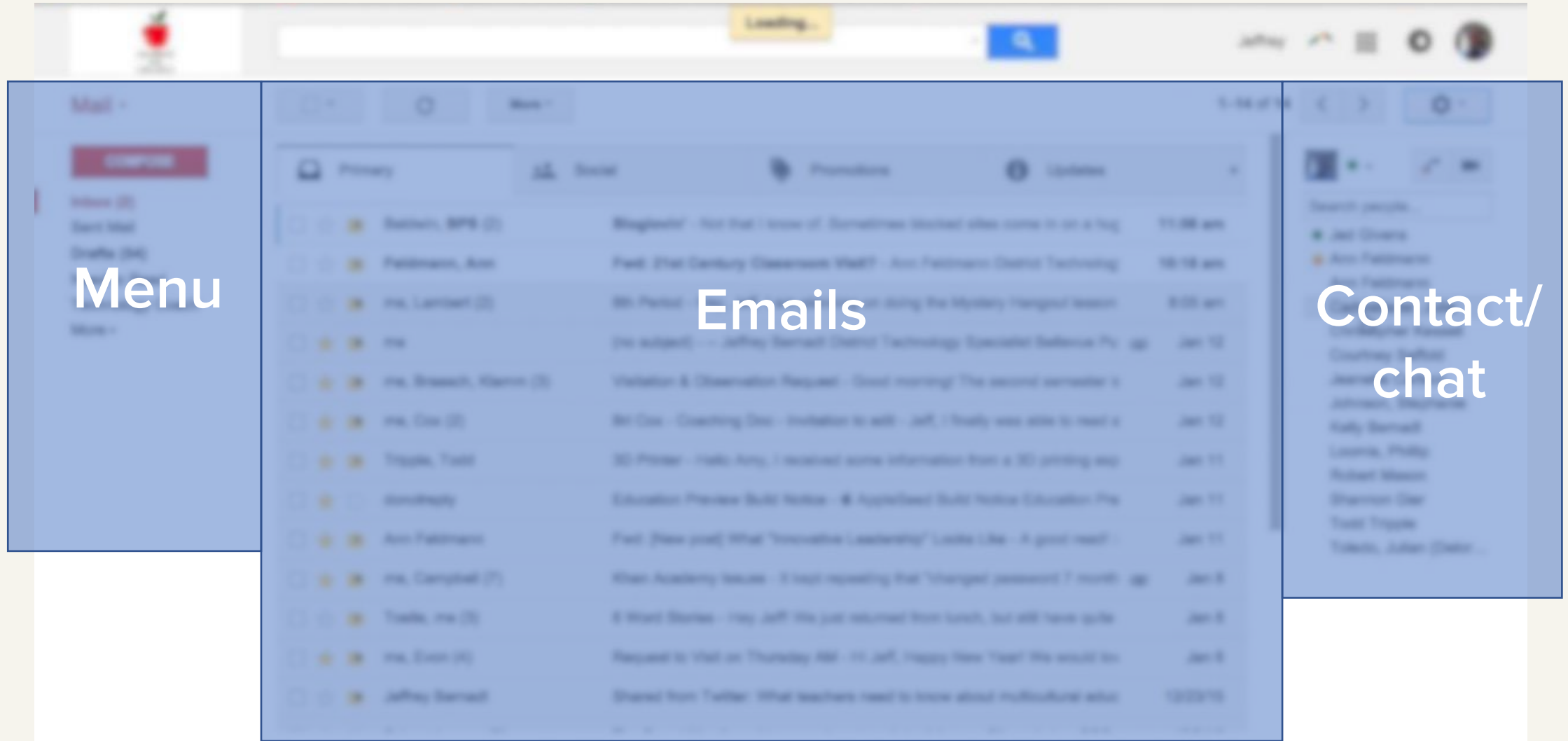
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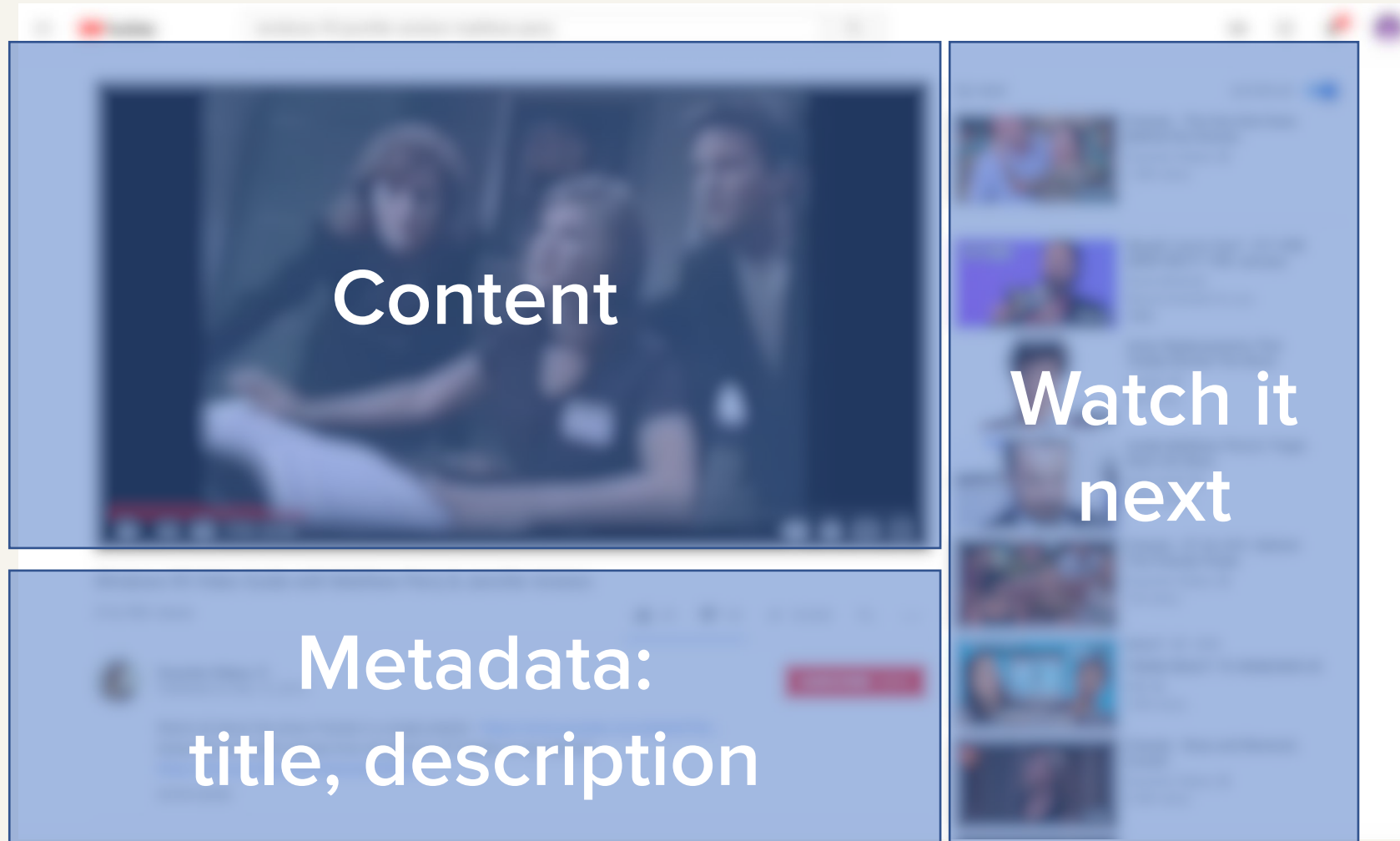
1. Conceptual Grouping:

A few high-level visual groups (3)



1. Conceptual Grouping:

A few high-level visual groups (3)

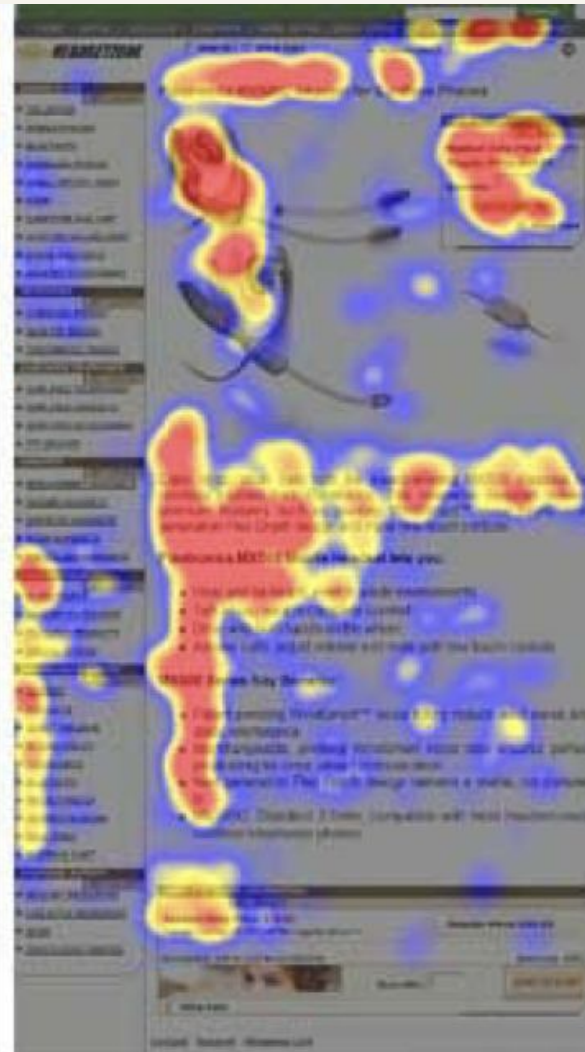
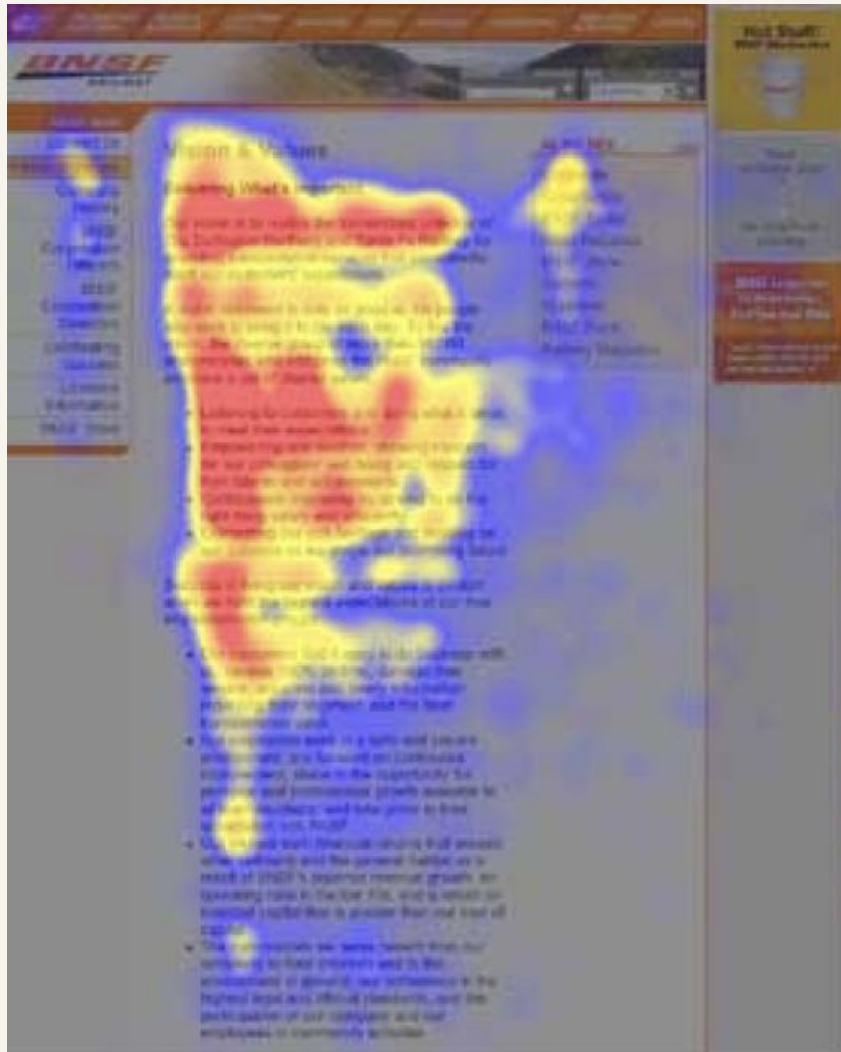


2. Location indicates Importance



2. Location indicates Importance

Gaze tracking shows the F-Shape of attention



3. Whitespace indicates Importance



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User Interface Design

COMS 4170 · Spring 2018

[Home](#) [Syllabus](#) [Assignments ▾](#) [Piazza](#)

Part 1 Build websites that suit the needs and abilities of users.

Part 2 When the needs and abilities of users are uncertain, design systems by learning from iteration and experimentation.

INSTRUCTOR	TAS	WEEKLY SCHEDULE
Prof. Lydia Chilton OH: Tuesday 3-4 pm, CEPSR 612 Please contact staff through Piazza only	Tessa Hurr Eleanor Murguia Lucille Sui	Lecture Mon, Wed 4:10-5:25pm, 413 Kent Hall



Whitespace vs No Whitespace



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User Interface Design

COMS 4170 · Spring 2018

Home Syllabus Assignments ▾

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Home Syllabus Assignments ▾

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---	--	--------------------------------------



3. Whitespace indicates importance



amazon prime

The James Harden Store

Deliver to Lydia
New York 10025

Buy Again Browsing History Lydia's Amazon.com Today's Deals Gift Cards Whole Foods Registry Sell Help

EN Hello, Lydia
Account & Lists

The James Harden Store

New Year, New You

Adriana Lima Store

Zac Efron Store

The Celebrity Store

Wireless Headphones

Performance Logo Pants

Exercise Bands

Elliptical Trainers

Sports Beverage

Men's Deodorant

3. Whitespace indicates importance



Art



Mona Lisa

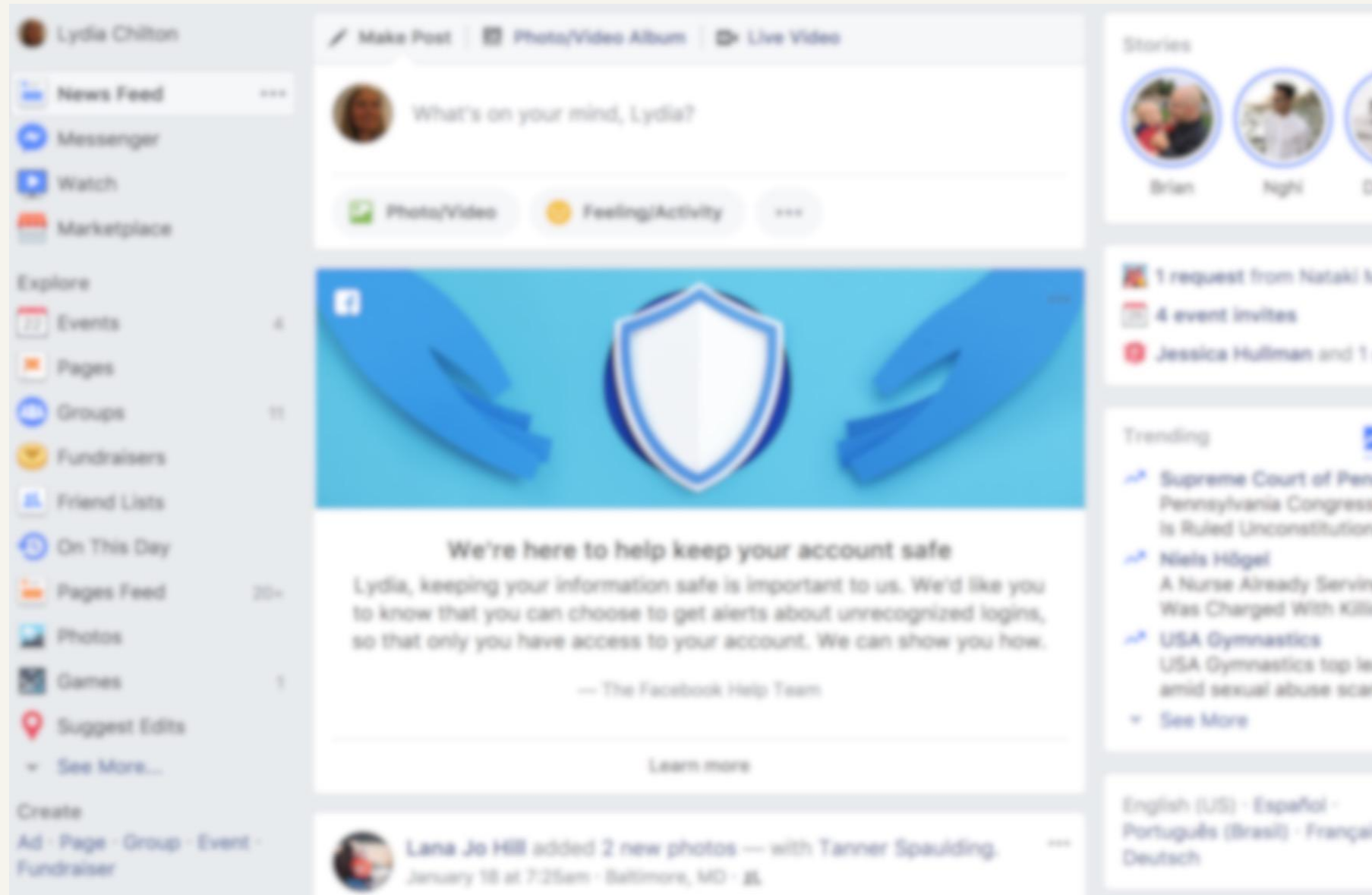
4. Size indicates importance



4. Size indicates importance



5. Images indicate importance



5. Images indicate importance





Menu

World

Europe

France

Environment

Opinion

M Magazine

French Delights

Subscribe

US tariff threats over Greenland pose 'more political than economic' consequences for Europe



OLIVIER DOULIERY/AFP

From January to November 2025, European exports to the US increased by 2%, despite the tariffs implemented by the Trump administration. The impact, however, was more severe in certain subsectors, including wine.

EU Parliament freezes US trade deal ratification after Trump's tariff threats over Greenland

Trump renews threats against a favorite target: French wines and spirits



SARAH MEYSSONNIER / REUTERS

French PM forces part of 2026 budget through Parliament without a vote



LUDOVIC MARIN / AFP

Macron denounces US competition seeking to 'subordinate Europe'



INTERVIEW
Ariane Ferrand

Bastien François, political scientist: 'There are good and bad ways to use Article 49.3' of the French Constitution

French Prime Minister Sébastien Lecornu's decision to ram the budget through Parliament without a vote, using Article 49.3 of the Constitution, is not undemocratic, explains political science professor Bastien François.

8 min read

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36

6. Contrast indicates importance



**Bold
increases
contrast**

**Greyscale
reduces
contrast**

You are cordially invited to

**Robert and Alexandra's
delectable after dinner party.**

Wine and nibbles will be served.

When: **February 20th, 2018 at 9:30pm.**

Where: **the pad.** If you need directions, ping us.

Kindly let us know if you will be attending by **February 1**

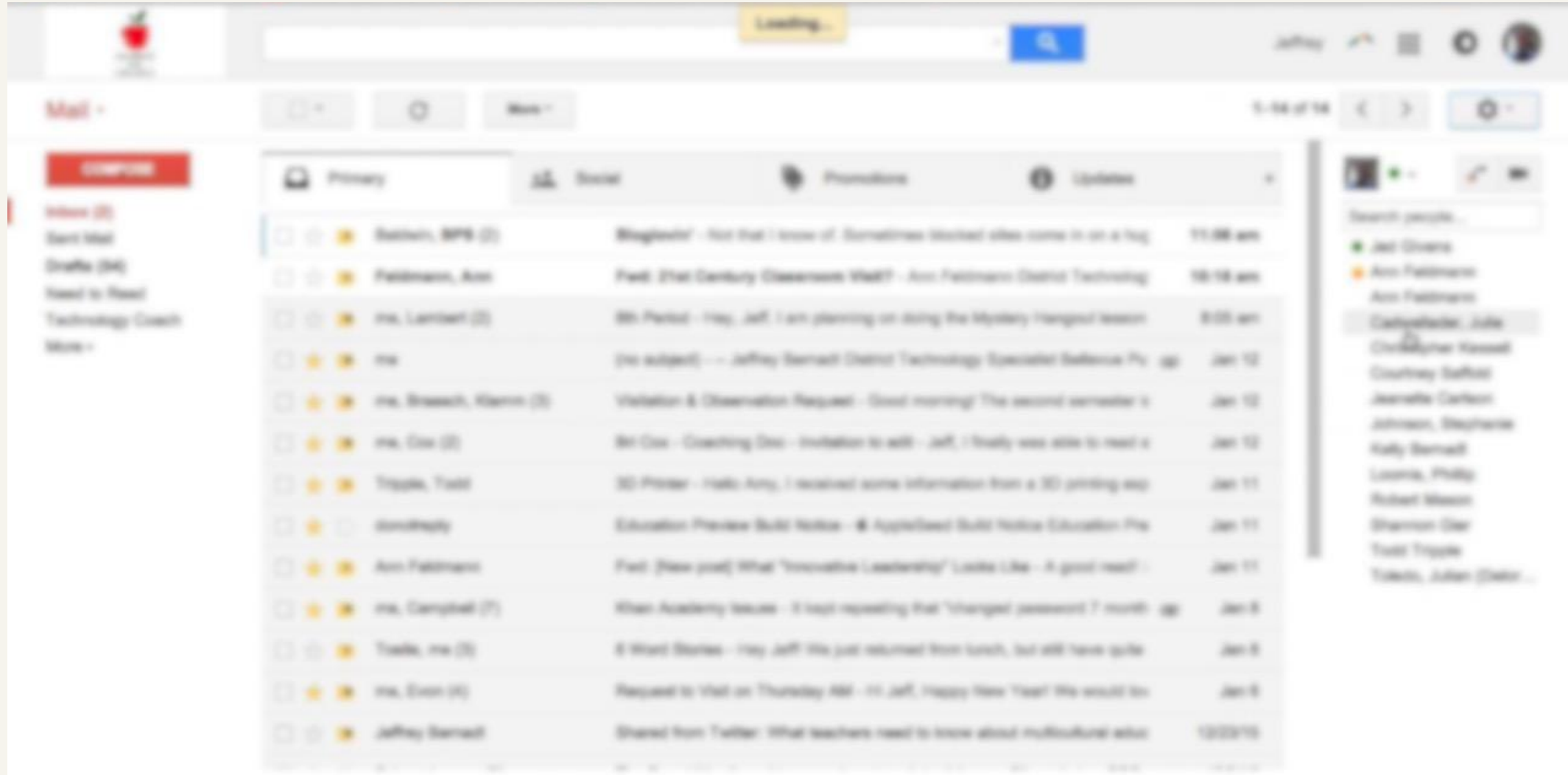


6. Contrast indicates importance



Bold
increases
contrast

Greyscale
reduces
contrast



7. Color indicates importance



Or start a new account

Choose a username (no spaces)

test

Choose a password

123

Repeat password

Email address (must be valid)

test@getmail

☒ Send me occasional blog updates.

test is already taken. Please choose a different username.

Passwords must be at least 8 characters and can only contain letters and numbers.

The email provider does not appear to be valid.



Seven tools for visually indicating importance



You are cordially invited to
Robert and Alexandra's delectable after dinner
party.

Wine and nibbles will be served.

When: February 20th, 2018 at 9:30pm.
Where: the pad. If you need directions, ping us.

Kindly let us know if you will be attending by
February 1st.

**Conceptual
grouping**



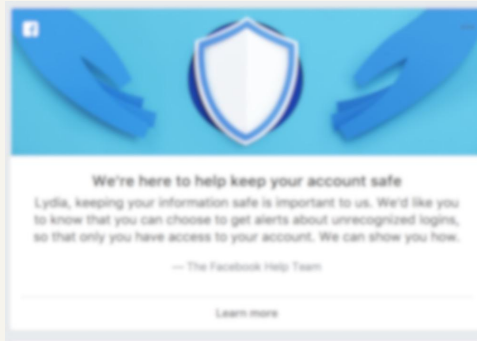
Location



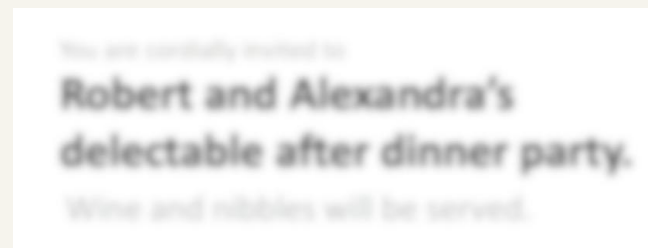
Whitespace



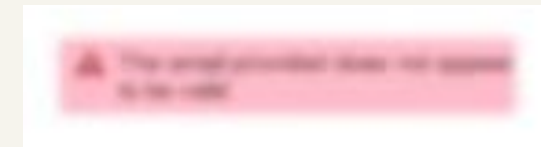
Size



Images



Contrast



Color

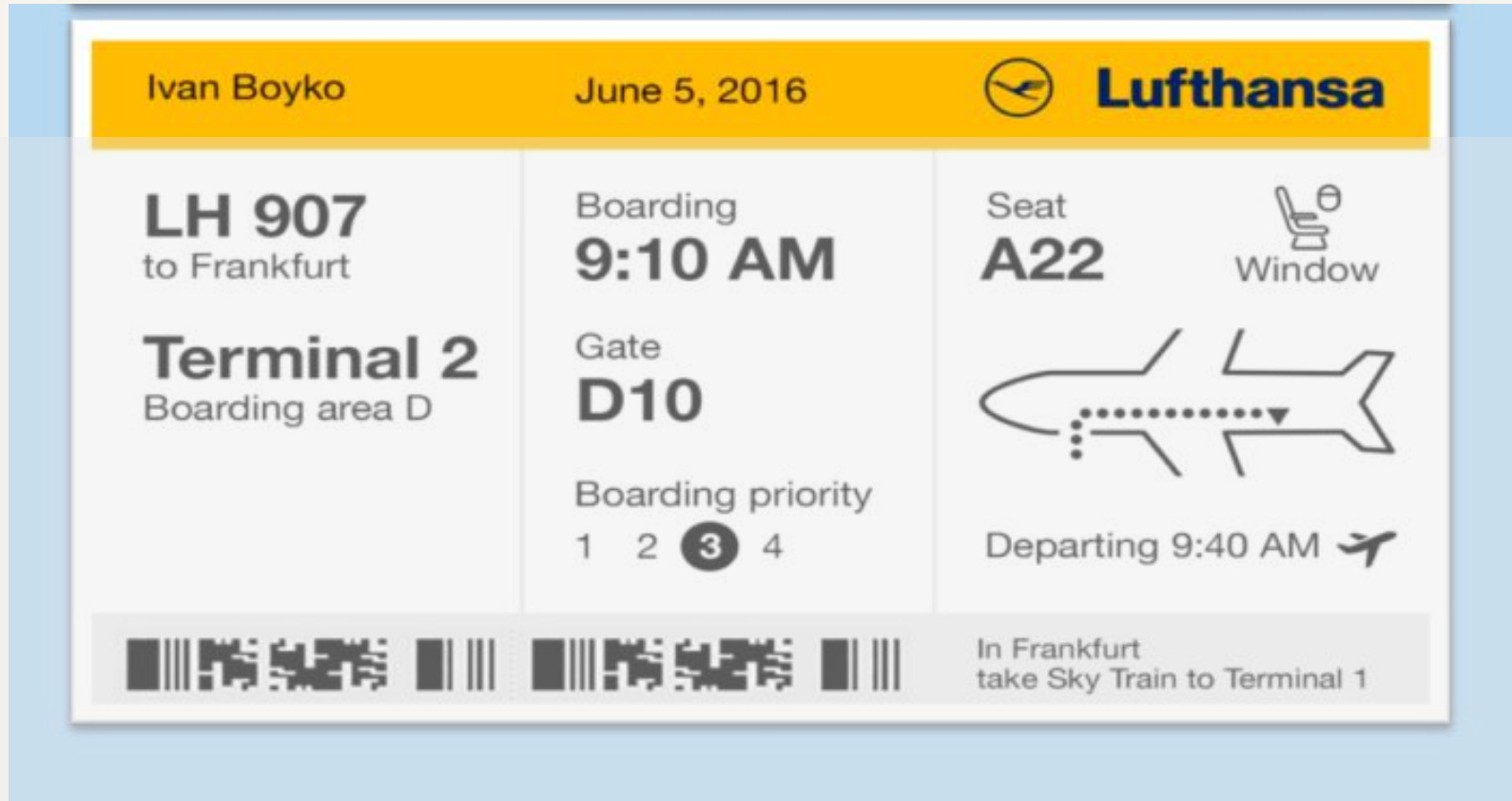


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Example



Let's analyze a boarding pass.



Who is the user?

Someone taking a flight
to Frankfurt

What is the users'
primary goal?

To get through the
airport to their seat on
the plane



What is the concept behind Group 1?



Ivan Boyko June 5, 2016 **Lufthansa**

LH 907
to Frankfurt

Terminal 2
Boarding area D

Boarding **9:10 AM**

Gate **D10**

Boarding priority
1 2 **3** 4

Seat **A22** Window

Departing 9:40 AM

In Frankfurt take Sky Train to Terminal 1

Get to the Terminal



What is the concept behind Group 2?



Ivan Boyko June 5, 2016 Lufthansa

LH 907
to Frankfurt

Terminal 2
Boarding area D

Boarding
9:10 AM

Gate
D10

Boarding priority
1 2 **3** 4

Seat
A22

Window

Departing 9:40 AM

In Frankfurt
take Sky Train to Terminal 1

Board the plane



What is the concept behind Group 3?



Ivan Boyko June 5, 2016 Lufthansa

LH 907
to Frankfurt

Terminal 2
Boarding area D

Boarding
9:10 AM

Gate
D10

Boarding priority
1 2 **3** 4

Seat
A22 Window

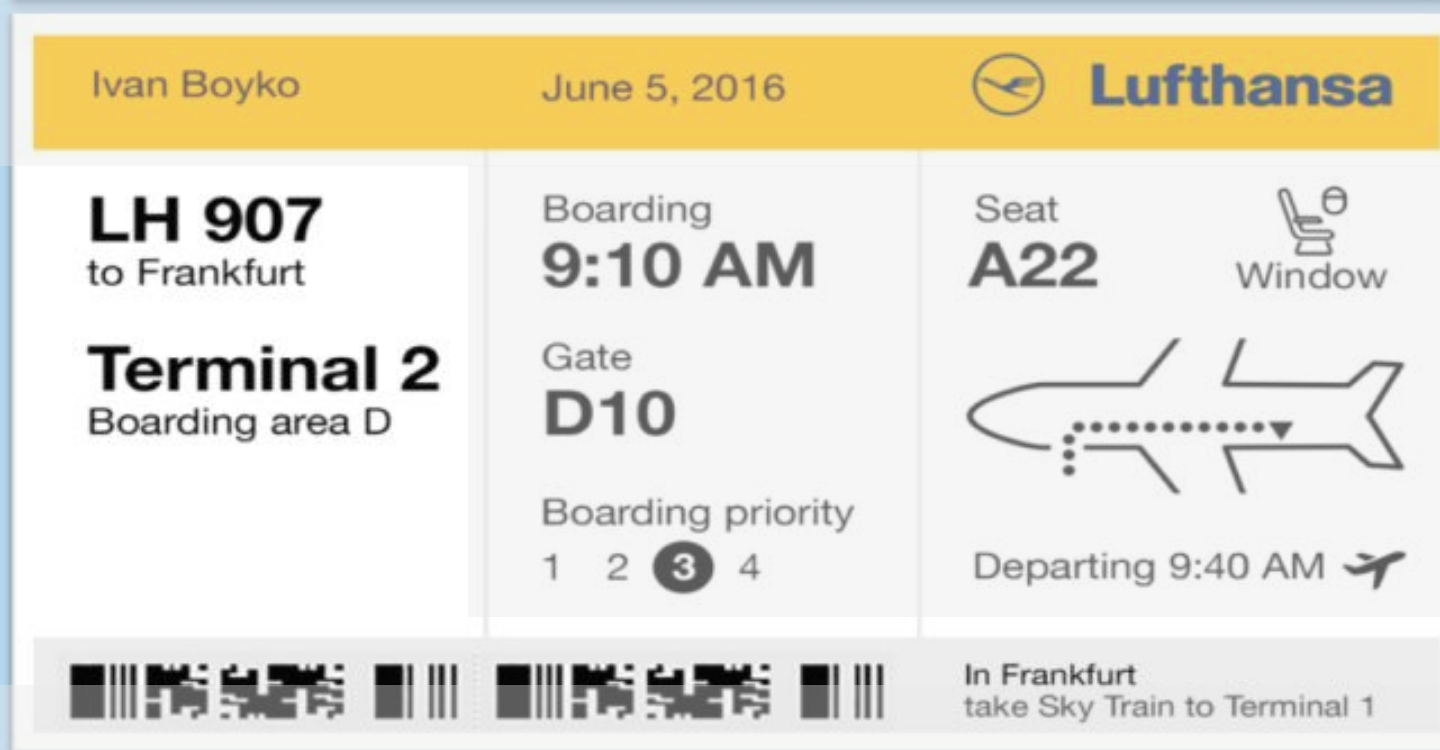
Departing 9:40 AM

In Frankfurt
take Sky Train to Terminal 1

Find your seat



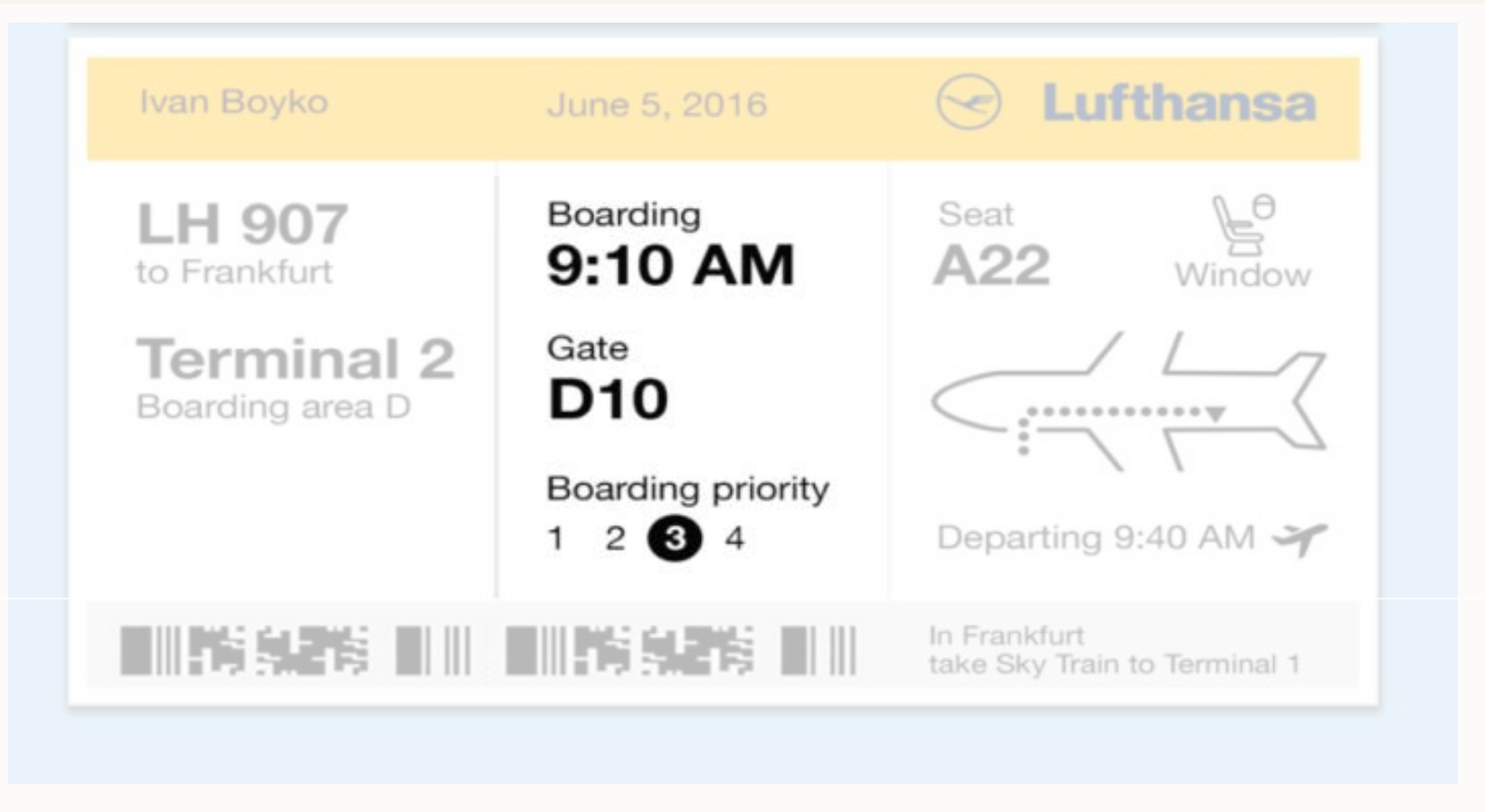
What tools does the “get to the terminal” group use?



- Whitespace
- Size
- Contrast
- Order



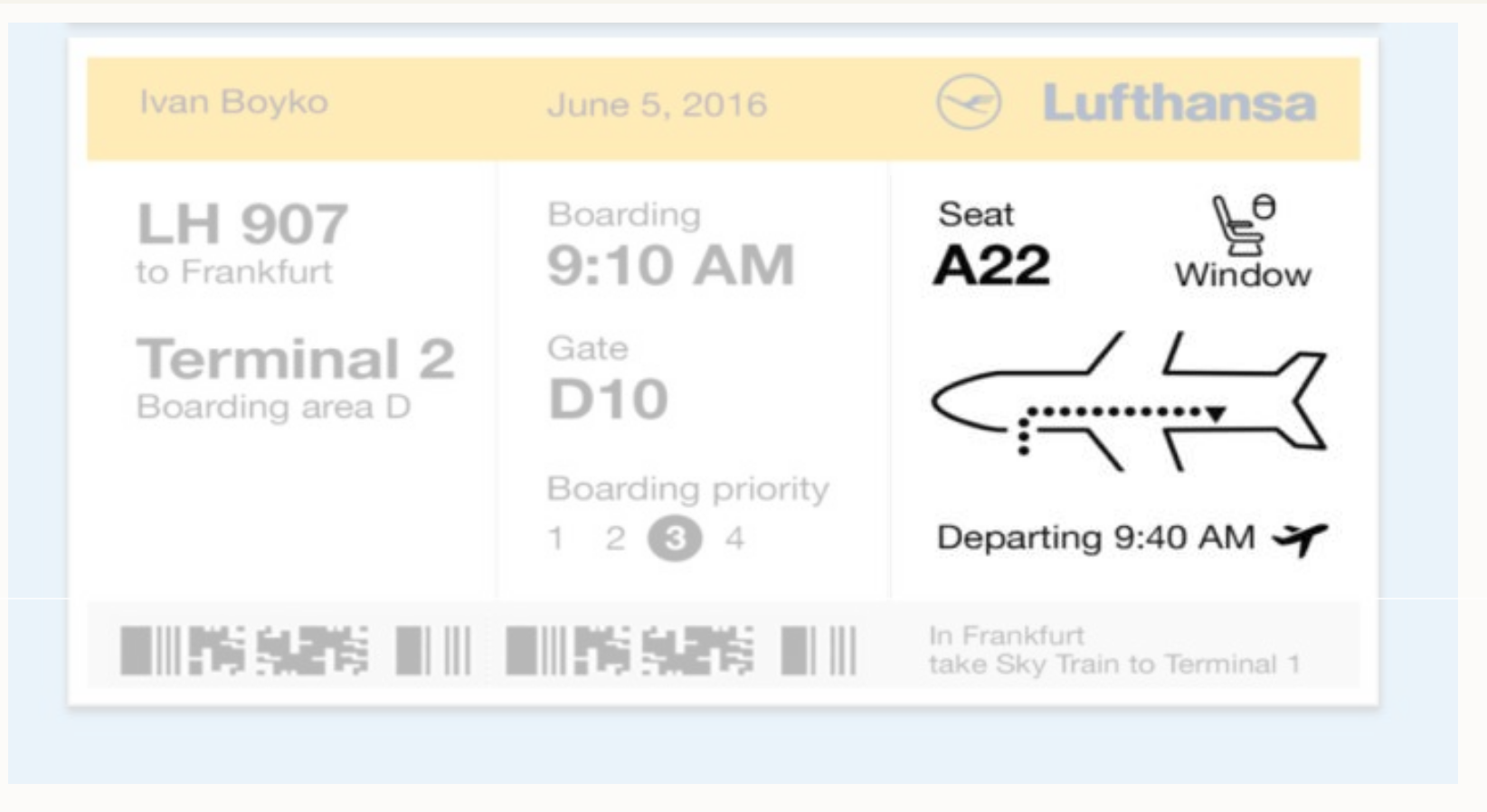
What tools does the “boarding” group use?



- Whitespace
- Size
- Contrast



What tools does the “find your seat” group use? ☐ ☐ ☐



- Images
- Size
- Contrast



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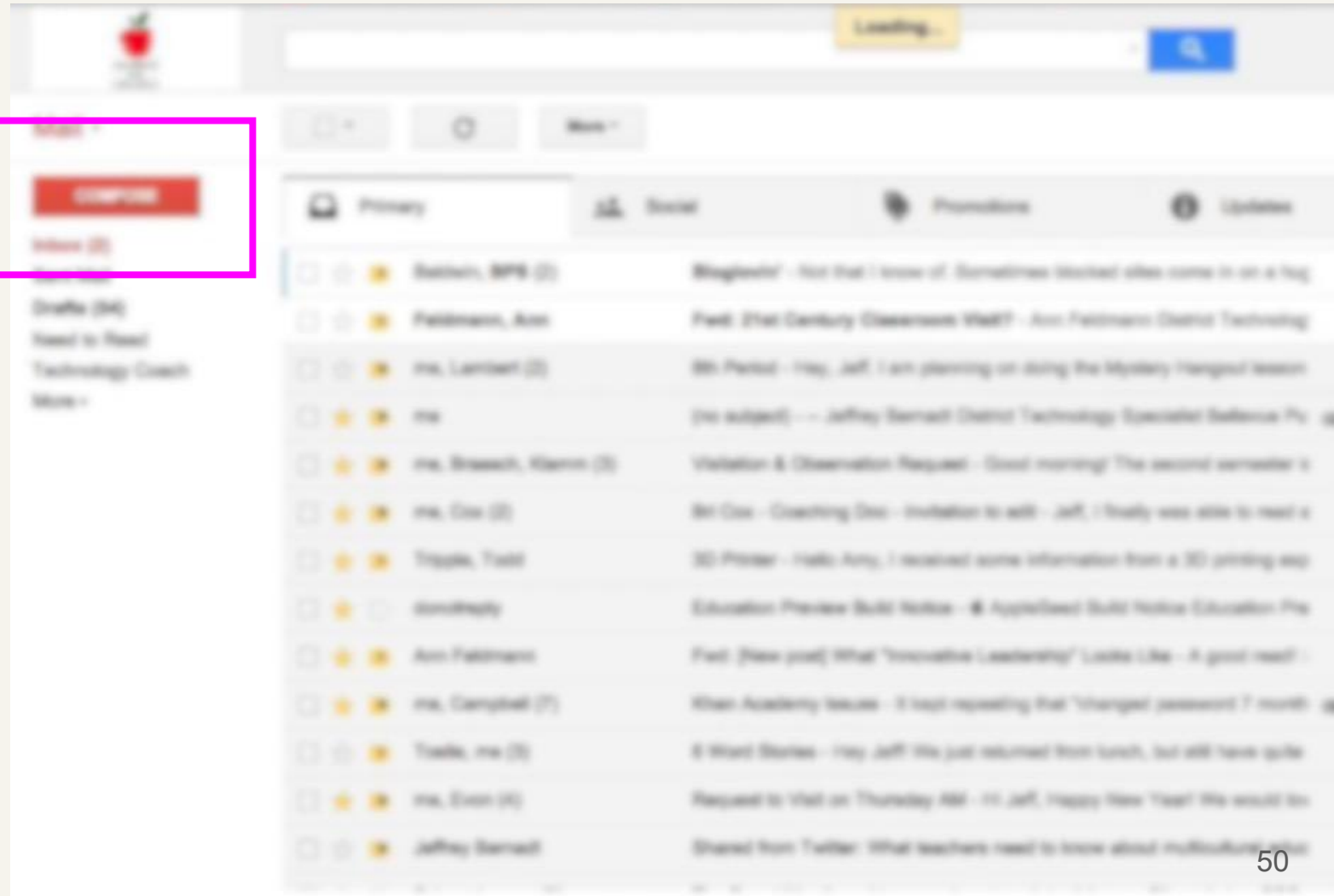
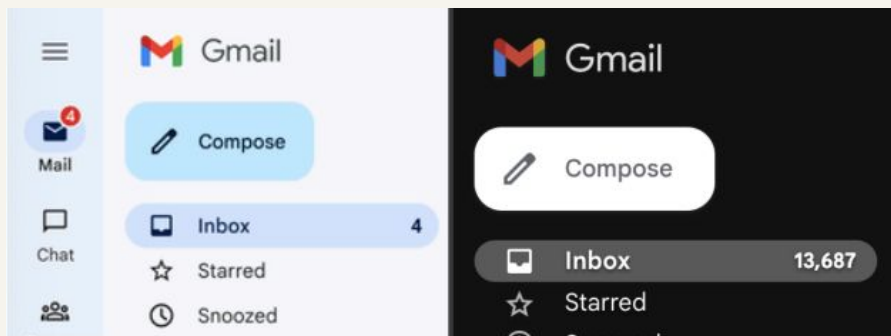
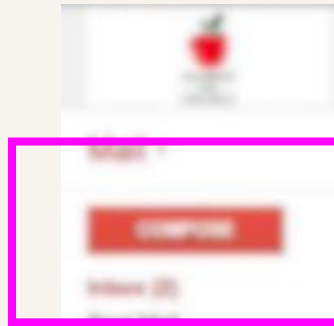
Using the Tools Together



What tools does the compose button use?



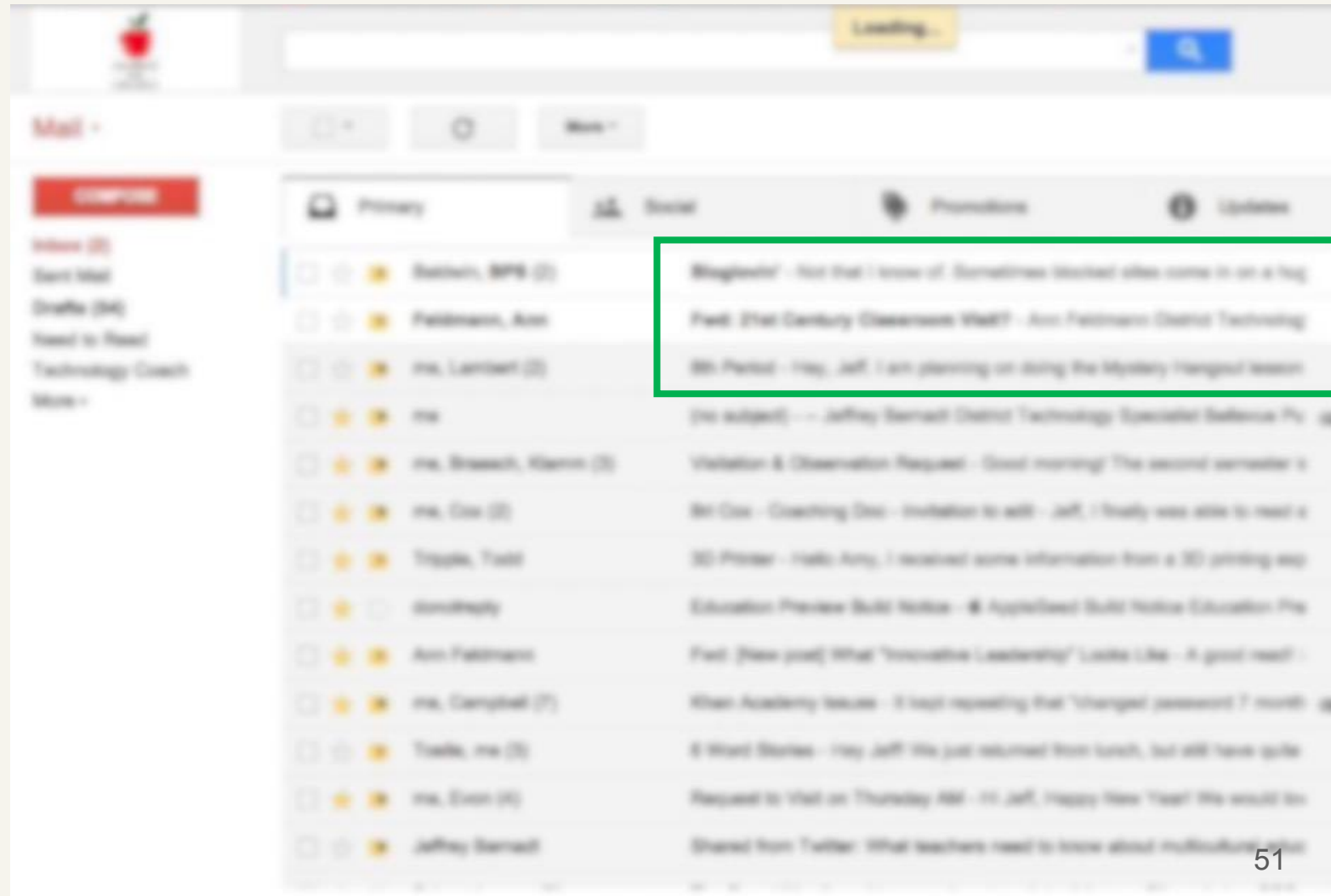
1. Conceptual Groupings? **Grouped with “menu”**
2. Position? **Top and left**
3. Whitespace? **Top and right**
4. Size? **Big**
5. Images? **No**
6. Contrast? **Dark box**
7. Color? **No**



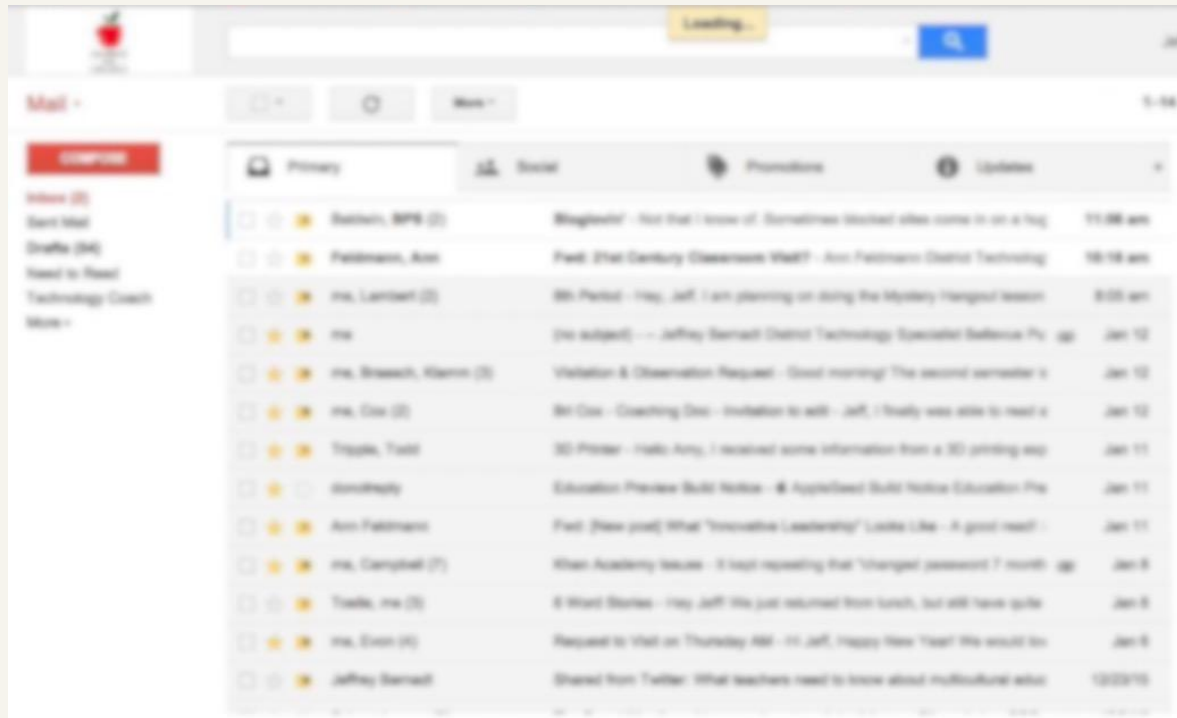
What tools does the unread message use?



- | | | |
|----|-----------------------|--------------|
| 1. | Conceptual Groupings? | All Messages |
| 2. | Position? | Top |
| 3. | Whitespace? | Left |
| 4. | Size? | No |
| 5. | Images? | No |
| 6. | Contrast? | Bold |
| 7. | Color? | No |



What tool do good designers use least?



Designers use color sparingly



What tool do novice designer over use?



19 German Draft Beers
Outdoor Biergarten
Let's Strudel Baby!

Bavarian Brathaus
Authentic German Restaurant

To make your online Reservation NOW >>Click here

◇ Menu ◇

German Draft Beer (Fassbier)

Menu

Kinder Menu Dessert

Vegetarian Fare

Live Music

Oktoberfest 2012

CLOSED FOR THE SUMMER

Bavarian Brathaus

Prosit

Willkommen und Guten Appetit

Bavarian Brathaus



Why don't you need color?



1. Conceptual Groupings? Grouped with “menu”
2. Position? Top and left
3. Whitespace? Top and right
4. Size? Big
5. Images? No
6. Contrast? Dark box
7. Color? Red



Use multiple tools to indicate importance.
Use color last – only in addition to other tools.

If you are tempted to use color...please don't.



Use grouping, whitespace, size and contrast first.

You are cordially invited to Robert and Alexandra's delectable after dinner party. Wine and nibbles will be served. When: February 20th, 2019 at 9:30pm. Where: the pad. If you need directions, ping us. Kindly let us know if you will be attending by February 1st.

You are cordially invited to

**Robert and Alexandra's
delectable after dinner party.**

Wine and nibbles will be served.

When: **February 20th, 2019 at 9:30pm.**

Where: **the pad.** If you need directions, ping us.

Kindly let us know if you will be attending
by **February 1st.**



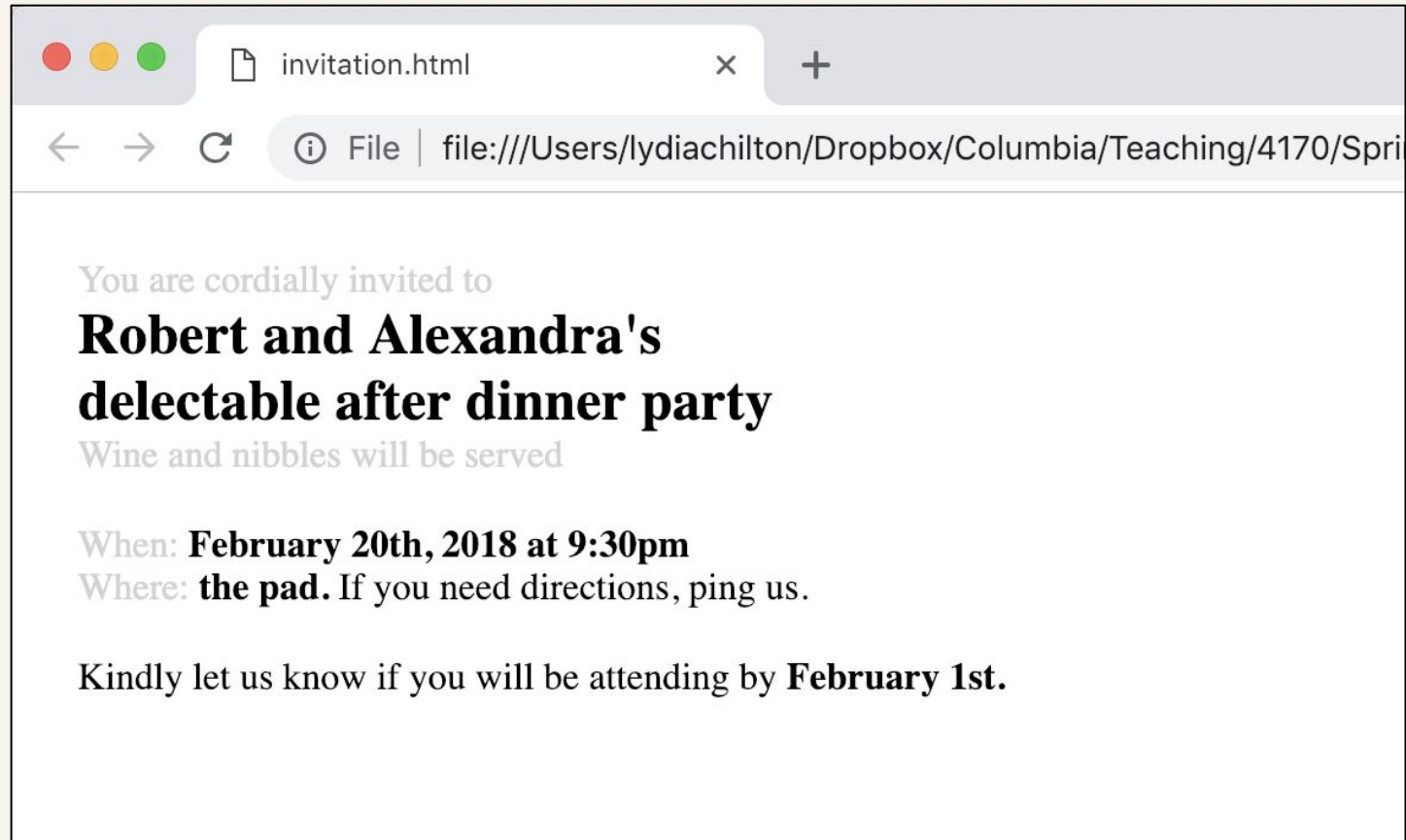
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Implementing Information Design



HTML Warm Up

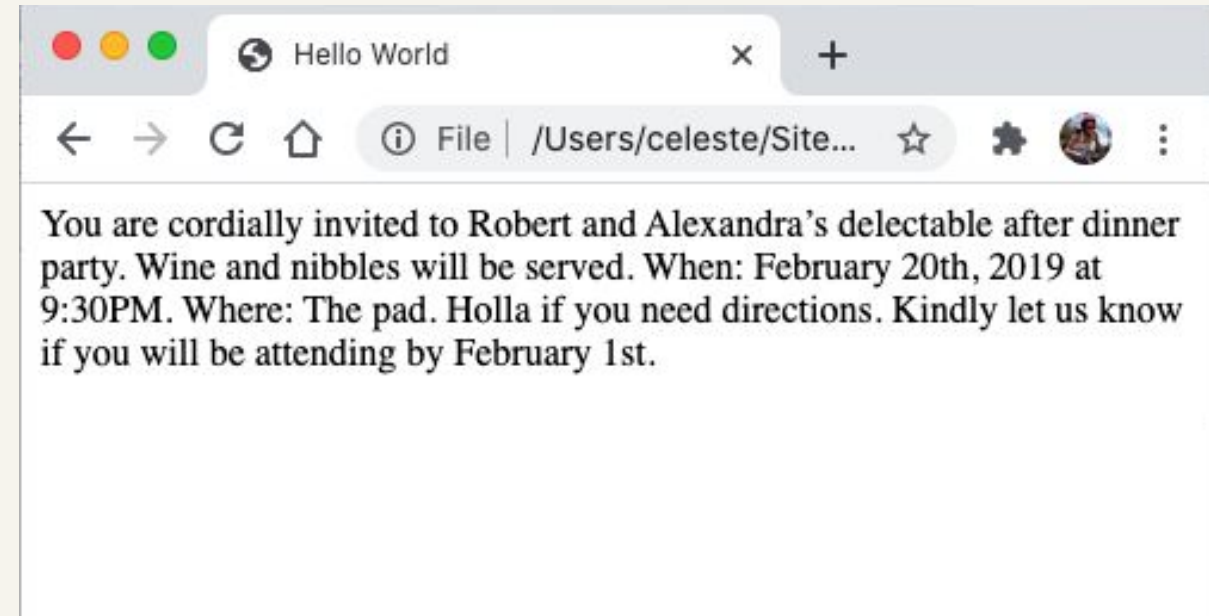
Remake the dinner party invitation



Step 1: Just run it.



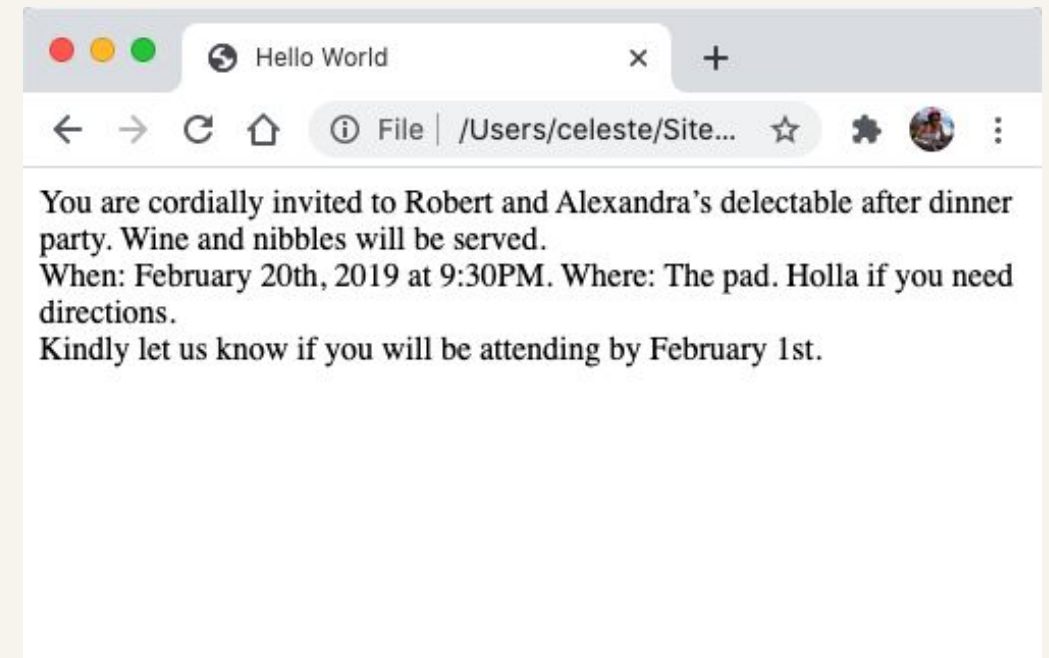
```
invitation0.html
1 <html>
2   <body>
3
4     You are cordially invited to
5     Robert and Alexandra's Dinner Party
6     Wine and nibbles will be served
7
8     When: February 20th, 2019 at 9:30pm
9     Where: the pad. If you need directions, ping us.
10
11     Kindly let us know if you will be attending by February 1st.
12
13
14   </body>
15 </html>
```



Step 2: Add `<div>` elements to create groups

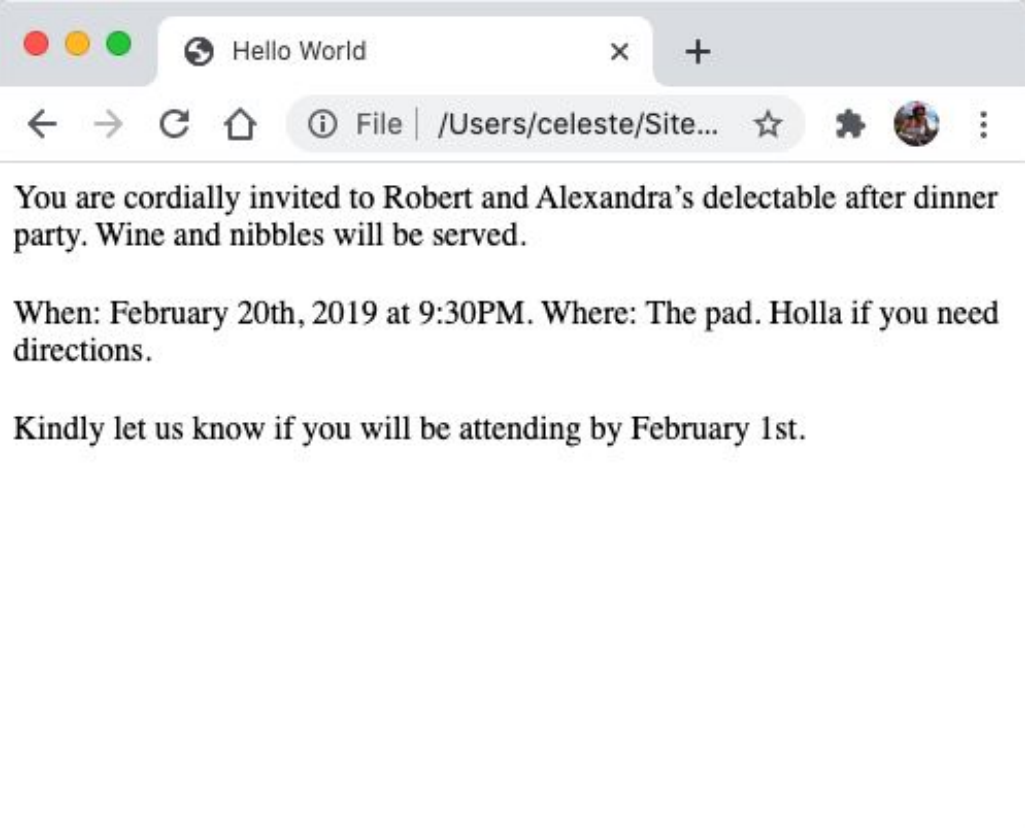


```
invitation0.html x
1 <html>
2   <body>
3     <div>
4       You are cordially invited to
5       Robert and Alexandra's Dinner Party
6       Wine and nibbles will be served
7     </div>
8     <div>
9       When: February 20th, 2019 at 9:30pm
10      Where: the pad. If you need directions, ping us.
11    </div>
12    <div>
13      Kindly let us know if you will be attending by February 1st.
14    </div>
15  </body>
16 </html>
```



Step 3: Add `<style>` in the `<head>`, and apply padding to divs

```
invitation0.html
1 <html>
2   <head>
3     <style>
4     div{
5       padding-bottom: 20px;
6     }
7   </style>
8 </head>
9 <body>
10  <div>
11    You are cordially invited to
12    Robert and Alexandra's Dinner Party
13    Wine and nibbles will be served
14  </div>
15  <div>
16    When: February 20th, 2019 at 9:30pm
17    Where: the pad. If you need directions, ping us.
18  </div>
19  <div>
20    Kindly let us know if you will be attending by February 1st.
21  </div>
22
23 </body>
24 </html>
```



You are cordially invited to Robert and Alexandra's delectable after dinner party. Wine and nibbles will be served.

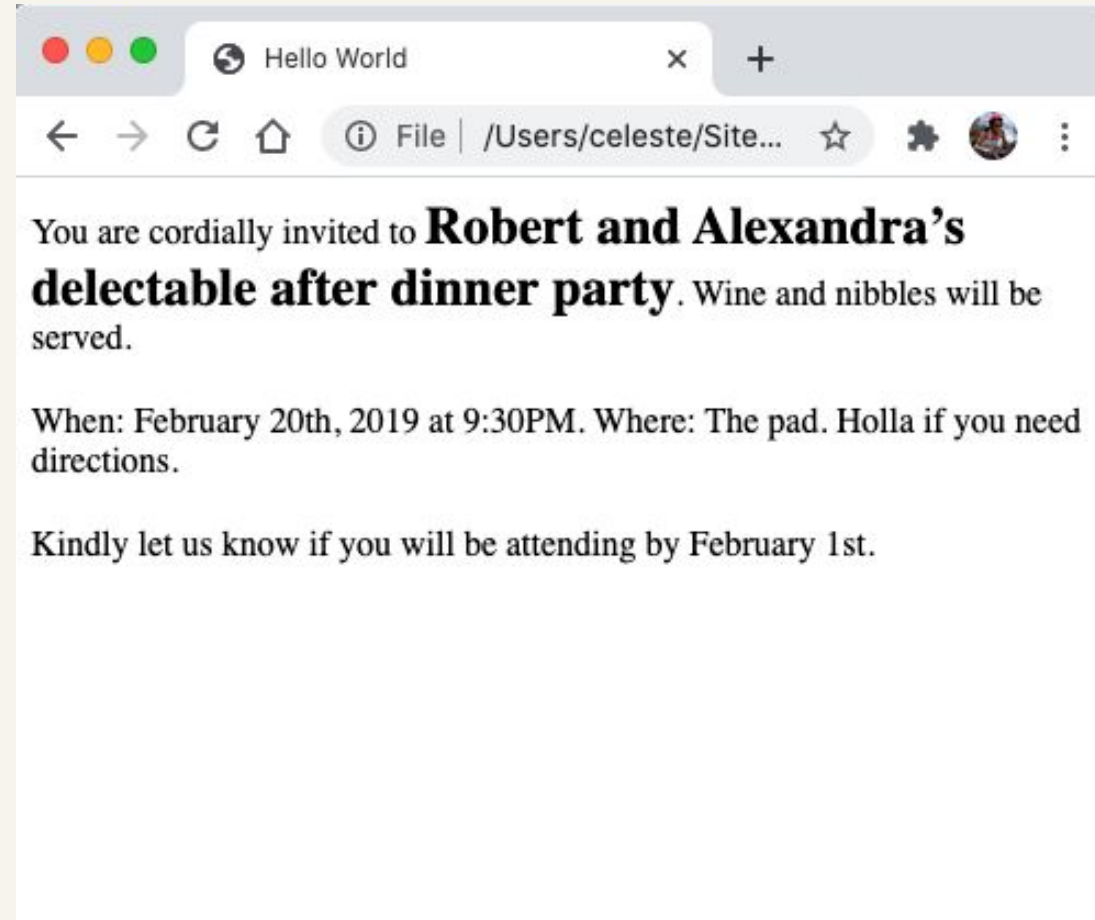
When: February 20th, 2019 at 9:30PM. Where: The pad. Holla if you need directions.

Kindly let us know if you will be attending by February 1st.



Step 4: Add tags and some styles by class

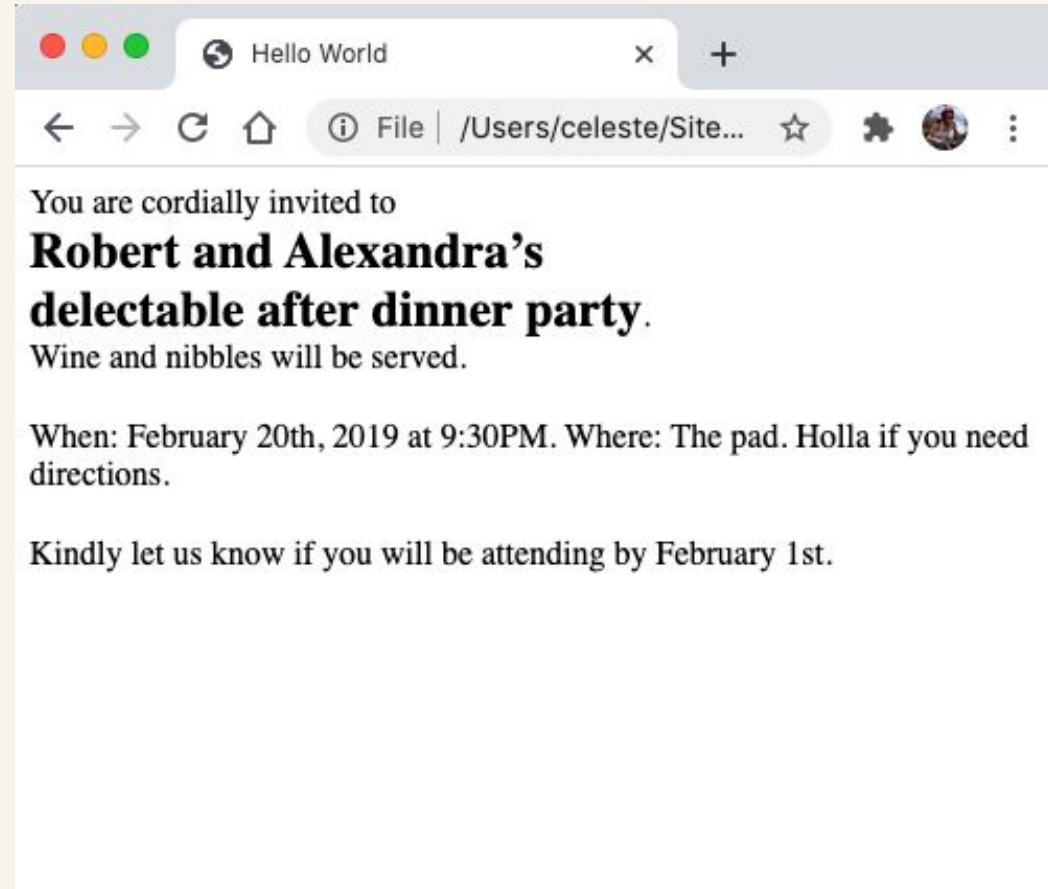
```
invitation0.html
1 <html>
2   <head>
3     <style>
4       div{
5         padding-bottom: 20px;
6       }
7
8       .dark{
9         font-weight: bold;
10      }
11
12      .big{
13        font-size: 24px;
14      }
15    </style>
16  </head>
17  <body>
18    <div>
19      You are cordially invited to
20      <span class="dark big">
21        Robert and Alexandra's
22        delectable after dinner party
23      </span>
24      Wine and nibbles will be served
25    </div>
26  </body>
27 </html>
```



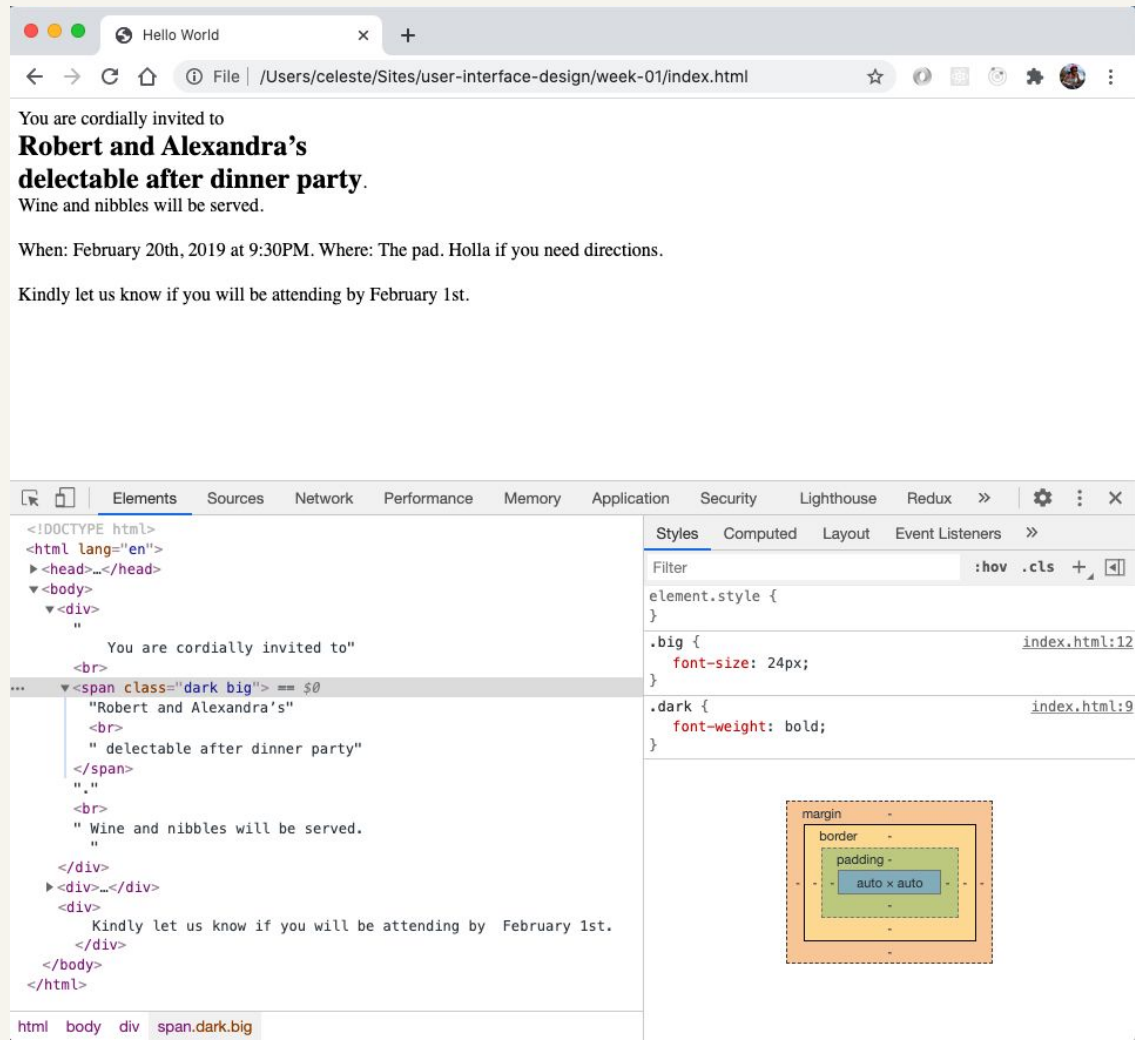
Step 5: Add `<br>` elements to break lines.



```
18     <body>
19         <div>
20             You are cordially invited to<br>
21             <span class="dark big">
22                 Robert and Alexandra's <br>
23                 delectable after dinner party
24             </span><br>
25             Wine and nibbles will be served
26         </div>
```



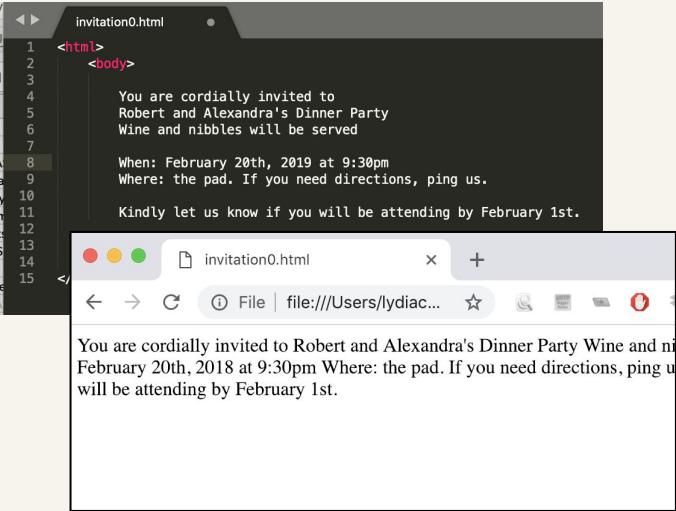
Developer Tools Demo



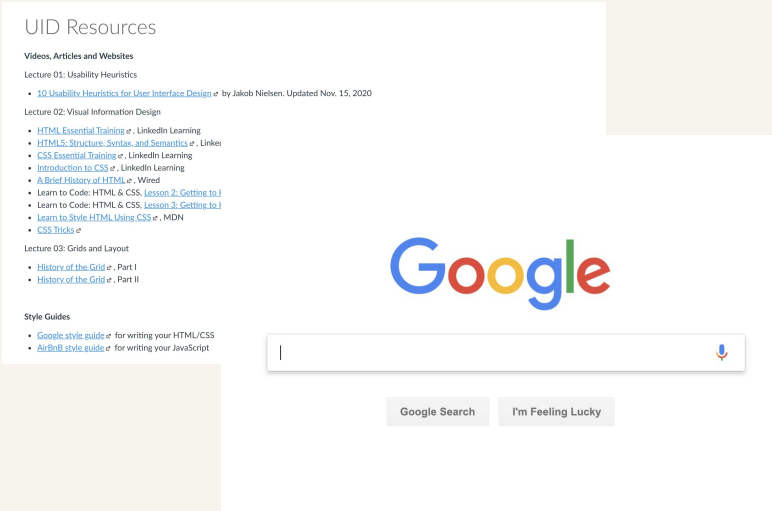
If you are new to HTML and CSS



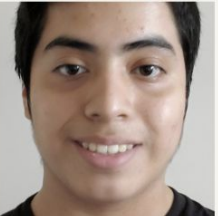
Try it



Ask Google & AI



Ask the staff

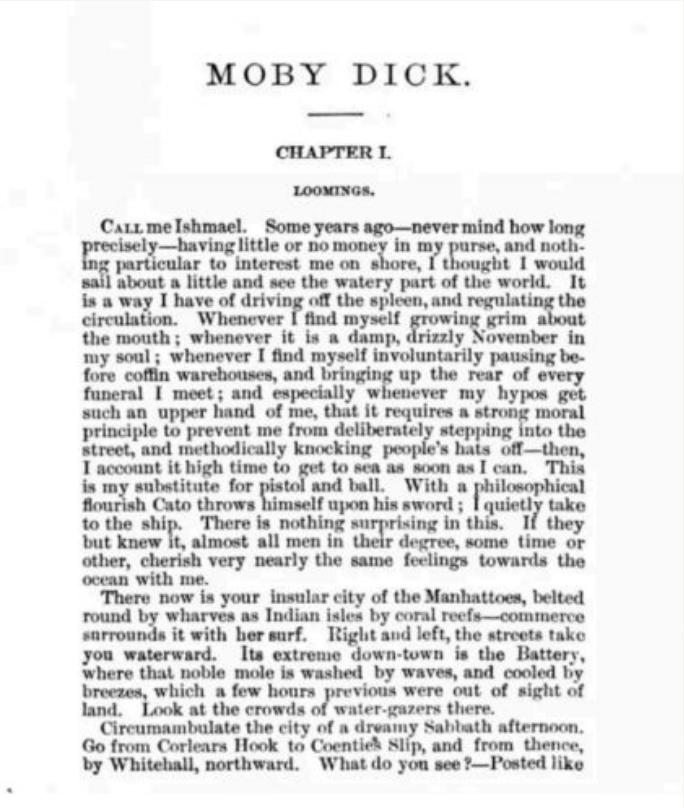


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Information Foraging Theory



Users don't read linearly. They browse based on information cues



Not like this

...but like this



Information Foraging Theory says users follow visual or textual clues to sense if they are on the right track.



craigslist

post to classifieds

my account

search craigslist

search

event calendar

M	T	W	T	F	S	S
15	16	17	18	19	20	21
22	23	24	25	26	27	28
29	30	31	1	2	3	4
5	6	7	8	9	10	11

help, faq, abuse, legal

avoid scams & fraud

personal safety tips

terms of use new

privacy policy

system status

about craigslist

craigslist is hiring in sf

craigslist open source

craigslist blog

best-of-craigslist

craigslist TV

"craigslist joe"

craig connects

progressive directory

weather quake tide

SF bay area

sfc sby eby pen nby scz

community

activities

artists

childcare

classes

events

general

groups

local news

lost+found

musicians

pets

politics

rideshare

volunteers

personals

strictly platonic

women seek women

women seeking men

men seeking women

men seeking men

misc romance

casual encounters

missed connections

rants and raves

discussion forums

apple

arts

atheist

autos

beauty

bikes

celebs

comp

crafts

diet

divorce

dying

eco

educ

feedback

film

fitness

fixit

food

frugal

help

history

housing

jobs

jokes

kink

legal

linux

m4m

manners

marriage

media

money

motocyc

music

nonprofit

open

outdoor

over 50

parent

photo

p.o.c.

politics

psych

queer

recover

religion

romance

science

spirit

sports

tax

travel

tv

vegan

w4w

wed

wine

women

words

housing

apts / housing

housing swap

housing wanted

office / commercial

parking / storage

real estate for sale

rooms / shared

rooms wanted

sublets / temporary

vacation rentals

for sale

antiques

appliances

arts+crafts

atv/utv/sno

auto parts

baby+kid

barter

beauty+hlth

bikes

boats

books

business

cars+trucks

cds/dvd/vhs

cell phones

clothes+acc

collectibles

computers

electronics

farm+garden

free

furniture

garage sale

general

heavy equip

household

jewelry

materials

motorcycles

music instr

photo+video

rvs+camp

sporting

tickets

tools

toys+games

trailers

video gaming

wanted

services

automotive

beauty

cell/mobile

computer

creative

legal

lessons

marine

pet

real estate

jobs

accounting+finance

admin / office

arch / engineering

art / media / design

biotech / science

business / mgmt

customer service

education

food / bev / hosp

general labor

government

human resources

internet engineers

legal / paralegal

manufacturing

marketing / pr / ad

medical / health

nonprofit sector

real estate

retail / wholesale

sales / biz dev

salon / spa / fitness

security

skilled trade / craft

software / qa / dba

systems / network

technical support

transport

tv / film / video

web / info design

writing / editing

[ETC]

[part-time]

gigs

computer

creative

crew

domestic

event

labor

talent

writing

english

nearby cl

bakersfield

chico

fresno

gold country

hanford

humboldt

inland empire

klamath falls

las vegas

los angeles

medford

mendocino co

merced

modesto

monterey

orange co

palm springs

redding

reno

roseburg

sacramento

san luis obispo

santa barbara

santa maria

siskiyou co

stockton

susanville

ventura

visalia-tulare

yuba-sutter

us cities

us states

canada

cl worldwide



Information hierarchies help us guide users' spotlight of attention to different "information patches"

The screenshot displays the Craigslist website for the San Francisco Bay Area. The layout is organized into several main sections, each representing a different information patch. At the top, the location is set to 'SF bay area' with filters for various sub-regions (sfc, sby, eby, pen, nby, scz). The main navigation bar includes categories like 'community', 'housing', 'jobs', 'personals', 'discussion forums', 'services', and 'gigs'. A 'nearby cl' sidebar on the right lists other cities. The 'for sale' section is highlighted with a black box, and the 'music instr' link within it is also highlighted. The 'event calendar' on the left shows a weekly grid with dates 15 through 11. The 'help, faq, abuse, legal' section is also visible.

craigslist

post to classifieds
my account

search craigslist
search

event calendar

M	T	W	T	F	S	S
15	16	17	18	19	20	21
22	23	24	25	26	27	28
29	30	31	1	2	3	4
5	6	7	8	9	10	11

help, faq, abuse, legal
avoid scams & fraud
personal safety tips
terms of use new
privacy policy
system status

about craigslist
craigslist is hiring in sf
craigslist open source
craigslist blog
best-of-craigslist
craigslist TV
"craigslist joe"
craig connects
progressive directory
weather quake tide

community

activities local news
artists lost+found
childcare musicians
classes pets
events politics
general rideshare
groups volunteers

housing

apts / housing
housing swap
housing wanted
office / commercial
parking / storage
real estate for sale
rooms / shared
rooms wanted
sublets / temporary
vacation rentals

jobs

accounting+finance
admin / office
arch / engineering
art / media / design
biotech / science
business / mgmt
customer service
education
food / bev / hosp
general labor
government
human resources
internet engineers
legal / paralegal
manufacturing
marketing / pr / ad
medical / health
nonprofit sector
real estate
retail / wholesale
sales / biz dev
salon / spa / fitness
security
skilled trade / craft
software / qa / dba
systems / network
technical support
transport
tv / film / video
web / info design
writing / editing
[ETC]
[part-time]

personals

strictly platonic
women seek women
women seeking men
men seeking women
men seeking men
misc romance
casual encounters
missed connections
rants and raves

discussion forums

apple	help	photo
arts	history	p.o.c.
atheist	housing	politics
autos	jobs	psych
beauty	jokes	queer
bikes	kink	recover
celebs	legal	religion
comp	linux	romance
crafts	m4m	science
diet	manners	spirit
divorce	marriage	sports
dying	media	tax
eco	money	travel
educ	motocy	tv
feedbk	music	vegan
film	nonprofit	w4w
fitness	open	wed
fixit	outdoor	wine
food	over 50	women
frugal	parent	words

for sale

antiques	free
appliances	furniture
arts+crafts	garage sale
atv/utv/sno	general
auto parts	heavy equip
baby+kid	household
barter	jewelry
beauty+hlth	materials
bikes	motorcycles
boats	music instr
books	photo+video
business	rvs+camp
cars+trucks	sporting
cds/dvd/vhs	tickets
cell phones	tools
clothes+acc	toys+games
collectibles	trailers
computers	video gaming
electronics	wanted
farm+garden	

services

automotive	legal
beauty	lessons
cell/mobile	marine
computer	pet
creative	real estate

gigs

computer	event
creative	labor
crew	talent
domestic	writing

nearby cl

bakersfield
chico
fresno
gold country
hanford
humboldt
inland empire
klamath falls
las vegas
los angeles
medford
mendocino co
merced
modesto
monterey
orange co
palm springs
redding
reno
roseburg
sacramento
san diego
san joaquin
santa barbara
santa maria
siskiyou co
stockton
susanville
ventura
visalia-tulare
yuba-sutter

us cities

us states

canada

cl worldwide

Top level hierarchy

Second level hierarchy



Use simple labels to guide attention



craigslist

post to classifieds

my account

search craigslist

search

event calendar

M	T	W	T	F	S	S
15	16	17	18	19	20	21
22	23	24	25	26	27	28
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help, faq, abuse, legal

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progressive directory

weather quake tide

SF bay area

sfc sby eby pen nby scz

community

activities local news

artists lost+found

childcare musicians

classes pets

events politics

general rideshare

groups volunteers

personals

strictly platonic

women seek women

women seeking men

men seeking women

men seeking men

misc romance

casual encounters

missed connections

rants and raves

discussion forums

apple	help	photo
arts	history	p.o.c.
atheist	housing	politics
autos	jobs	psych
beauty	jokes	queer
bikes	kink	recover
celebs	legal	religion
comp	linux	romance
crafts	m4m	science
diet	manners	spirit
divorce	marriage	sports
dying	media	tax
eco	money	travel
educ	motocy	tv
feedbk	music	vegan
film	nonprofit	w4w
fitness	open	wed
fixit	outdoor	wine
food	over 50	women
frugal	parent	words

housing

apts / housing

housing swap

housing wanted

office / commercial

parking / storage

real estate for sale

rooms / shared

rooms wanted

sublets / temporary

vacation rentals

for sale

antiques	free
appliances	furniture
arts+crafts	garage sale
atv/utv/sno	general
auto parts	heavy equip
baby+kid	household
barter	jewelry
beauty+hlth	materials
bikes	motorcycles
boats	music instr
books	photo+video
business	rvs+camp
cars+trucks	sporting
cds/dvd/vhs	tickets
cell phones	tools
clothes+acc	toys+games
collectibles	trailers
computers	video gaming
electronics	wanted
farm+garden	

services

automotive

beauty

cell/mobile

computer

creative

legal

lessons

marine

pet

real estate

jobs

accounting+finance

admin / office

arch / engineering

art / media / design

biotech / science

business / mgmt

customer service

education

food / bev / hosp

general labor

government

human resources

internet engineers

legal / paralegal

manufacturing

marketing / pr / ad

medical / health

nonprofit sector

real estate

retail / wholesale

sales / biz dev

salon / spa / fitness

security

skilled trade / craft

software / qa / dba

systems / network

technical support

transport

tv / film / video

web / info design

writing / editing

[ETC]

[part-time]

gigs

computer

creative

crew

domestic

event

labor

talent

writing

english

nearby cl

bakersfield

chico

fresno

gold country

hanford

humboldt

inland empire

klamath falls

las vegas

los angeles

medford

mendocino co

merced

modesto

monterey

orange co

palm springs

redding

reno

roseburg

sacramento

santa barbara

santa maria

siskiyou co

stockton

susanville

ventura

visalia-tulare

yuba-sutter

us cities

us states

canada

cl worldwide

“For sale”

“Music instruments”



Caveat 1:



Use simple text labels BUT some data don't need labels.

The screenshot shows a Google search interface with the query 'columbia'. The search results page displays three main results. The first is an advertisement for Columbia's online store, featuring a green 'Ad' label and a list of product types and a discount. The second is a result for Columbia Sportswear, including a URL and a description of their outdoor clothing. The third is a result for Columbia University, including a URL and a description of campus events. The interface includes the Google logo, a search bar, navigation tabs (All, Maps, Images, News, Shopping, More), and settings/tools links.

Google

columbia

All Maps Images News Shopping More Settings Tools

About 647,000,000 results (0.66 seconds)

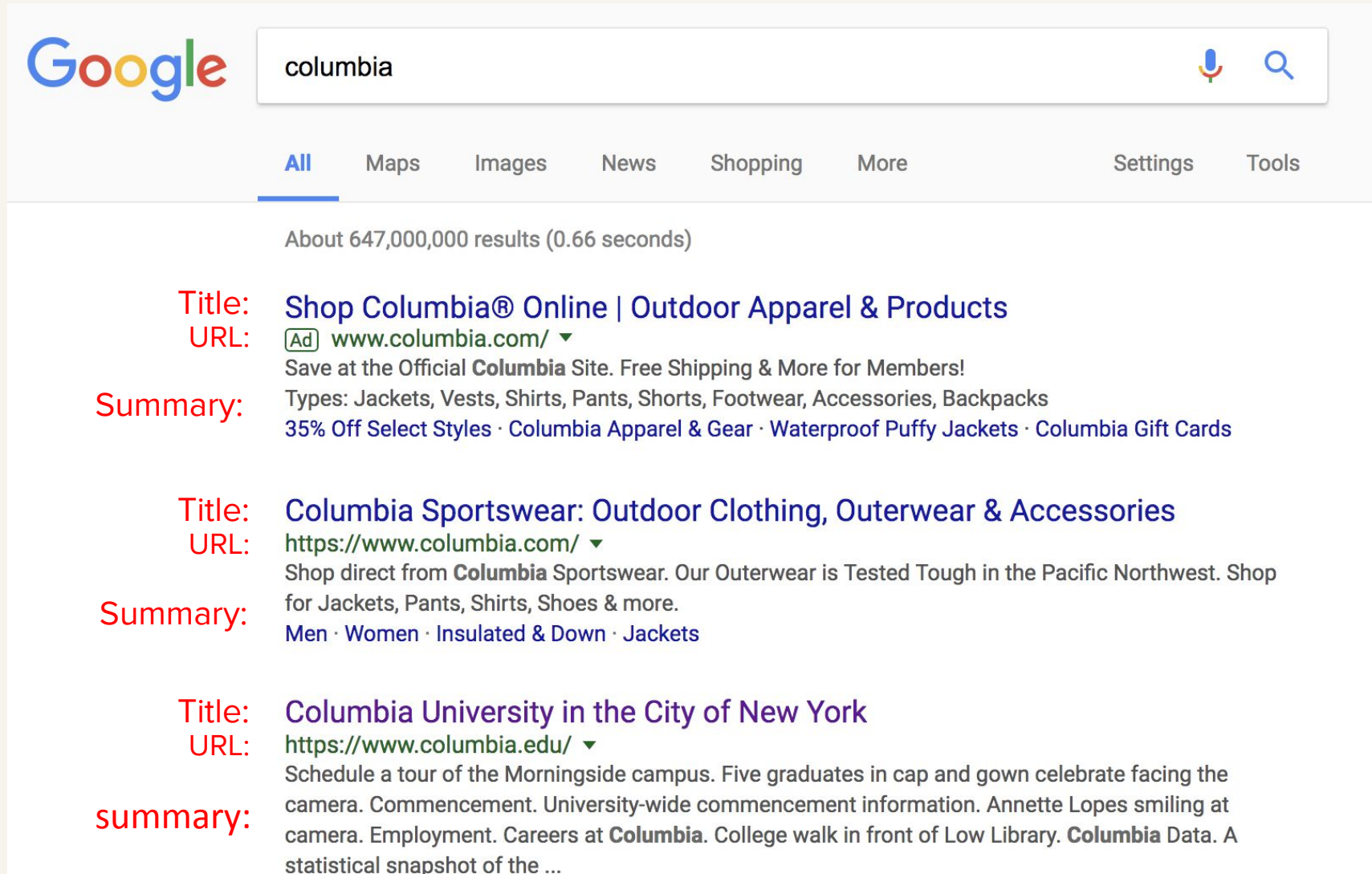
Shop Columbia® Online | Outdoor Apparel & Products
Ad www.columbia.com/ ▼
Save at the Official **Columbia** Site. Free Shipping & More for Members!
Types: Jackets, Vests, Shirts, Pants, Shorts, Footwear, Accessories, Backpacks
35% Off Select Styles · Columbia Apparel & Gear · Waterproof Puffy Jackets · Columbia Gift Cards

Columbia Sportswear: Outdoor Clothing, Outerwear & Accessories
<https://www.columbia.com/> ▼
Shop direct from **Columbia** Sportswear. Our Outerwear is Tested Tough in the Pacific Northwest. Shop for Jackets, Pants, Shirts, Shoes & more.
[Men](#) · [Women](#) · [Insulated & Down](#) · [Jackets](#)

Columbia University in the City of New York
<https://www.columbia.edu/> ▼
Schedule a tour of the Morningside campus. Five graduates in cap and gown celebrate facing the camera. Commencement. University-wide commencement information. Annette Lopes smiling at camera. Employment. Careers at **Columbia**. College walk in front of Low Library. **Columbia** Data. A statistical snapshot of the ...



Some data is “self-labeling”, adding labels adds clutter



The screenshot shows a Google search for "columbia". The search bar contains "columbia" and the Google logo is on the left. Below the search bar are tabs for "All", "Maps", "Images", "News", "Shopping", "More", "Settings", and "Tools". The search results show "About 647,000,000 results (0.66 seconds)".

Three search results are displayed, each with a label (Title, URL, Summary) in red text on the left:

- Title:** Shop Columbia® Online | Outdoor Apparel & Products
URL: www.columbia.com/ ▼
Summary: Save at the Official **Columbia** Site. Free Shipping & More for Members!
Types: Jackets, Vests, Shirts, Pants, Shorts, Footwear, Accessories, Backpacks
35% Off Select Styles · Columbia Apparel & Gear · Waterproof Puffy Jackets · Columbia Gift Cards
- Title:** Columbia Sportswear: Outdoor Clothing, Outerwear & Accessories
URL: <https://www.columbia.com/> ▼
Summary: Shop direct from **Columbia** Sportswear. Our Outerwear is Tested Tough in the Pacific Northwest. Shop for Jackets, Pants, Shirts, Shoes & more.
[Men](#) · [Women](#) · [Insulated & Down](#) · [Jackets](#)
- Title:** Columbia University in the City of New York
URL: <https://www.columbia.edu/> ▼
summary: Schedule a tour of the Morningside campus. Five graduates in cap and gown celebrate facing the camera. Commencement. University-wide commencement information. Annette Lopes smiling at camera. Employment. Careers at **Columbia**. College walk in front of Low Library. **Columbia** Data. A statistical snapshot of the ...



Caveat 2: Use familiar icons



...but DO NOT use unfamiliar icons.



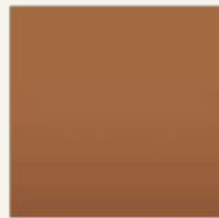
Account
View



...but DO NOT use unfamiliar icons.



My
Portfolio



...but DO NOT use unfamiliar icons.



LoanClick



...but DO NOT use unfamiliar icons.



Account
View



My
Portfolio



LoanClick



Transact



BillPayer



Online
Forms



Account
Notifications



User
Options



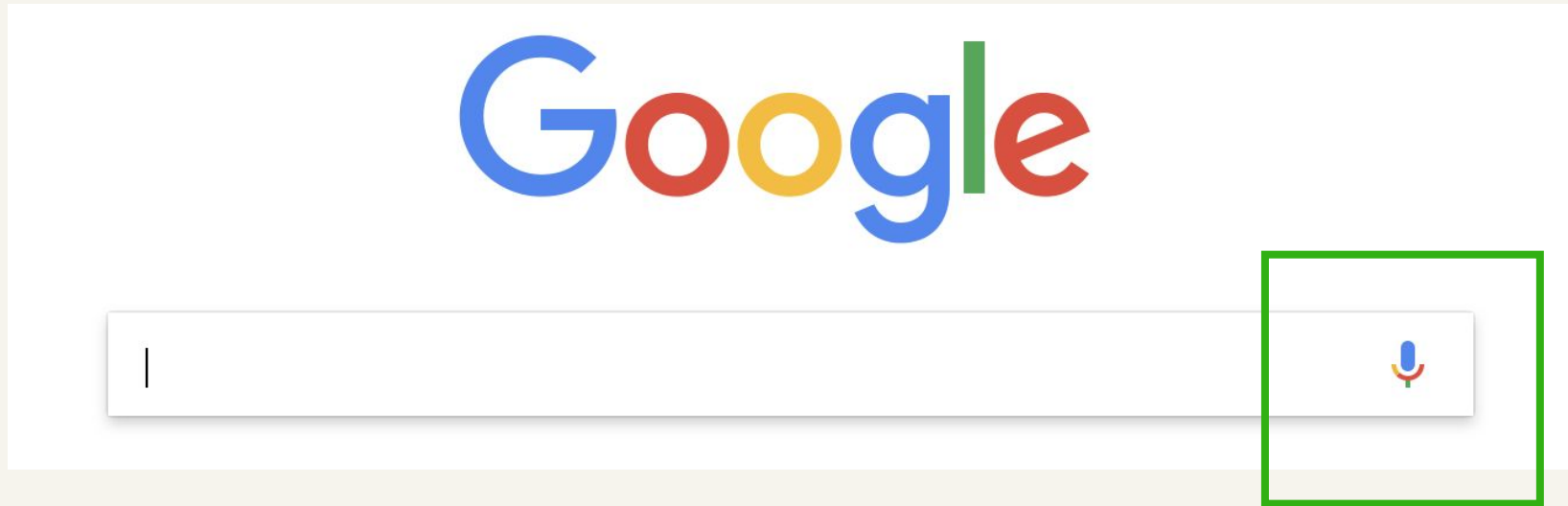
Help



Log Out



Icons are useful when users don't know the word for the object. 



Aesthetics matter to finding information







CHI 2012	Attend	Participate	Communities
• Home - About Us - Student Volunteers - Sponsors - Recruiters - Exhibitors - Press Information - Press Kit - Media Clippings - Conference Preview - DailyMedia Advisory	- About Austin - Housing - Registration & Visas - Advance Program - Printed Program (pdf) - Keynote Speakers - Invited Talks - Merchandise - Social Media - Locals' Night - Special Events	- Submissions & Dates - Papers & Notes - Alt.Chi - Case Studies - Courses - Doctoral Consortium - Interactivity - Panels - SIG Meetings - Student Competitions - Videos - Works-in-Progress - Workshops	- About Communities - CORE COMMUNITIES - Design - Engineering - Management - User Experience - FEATURED COMMUNITIES - Digital Arts - Games & Entertainment - HCI for Kids - Health - Sustainability

CHI 2012 Housing

The housing bureau is now closed. If you need to arrange your own accomodation near the conference, the address of the convention center is: 500 East Cesar Chavez Street Austin, TX 78701.

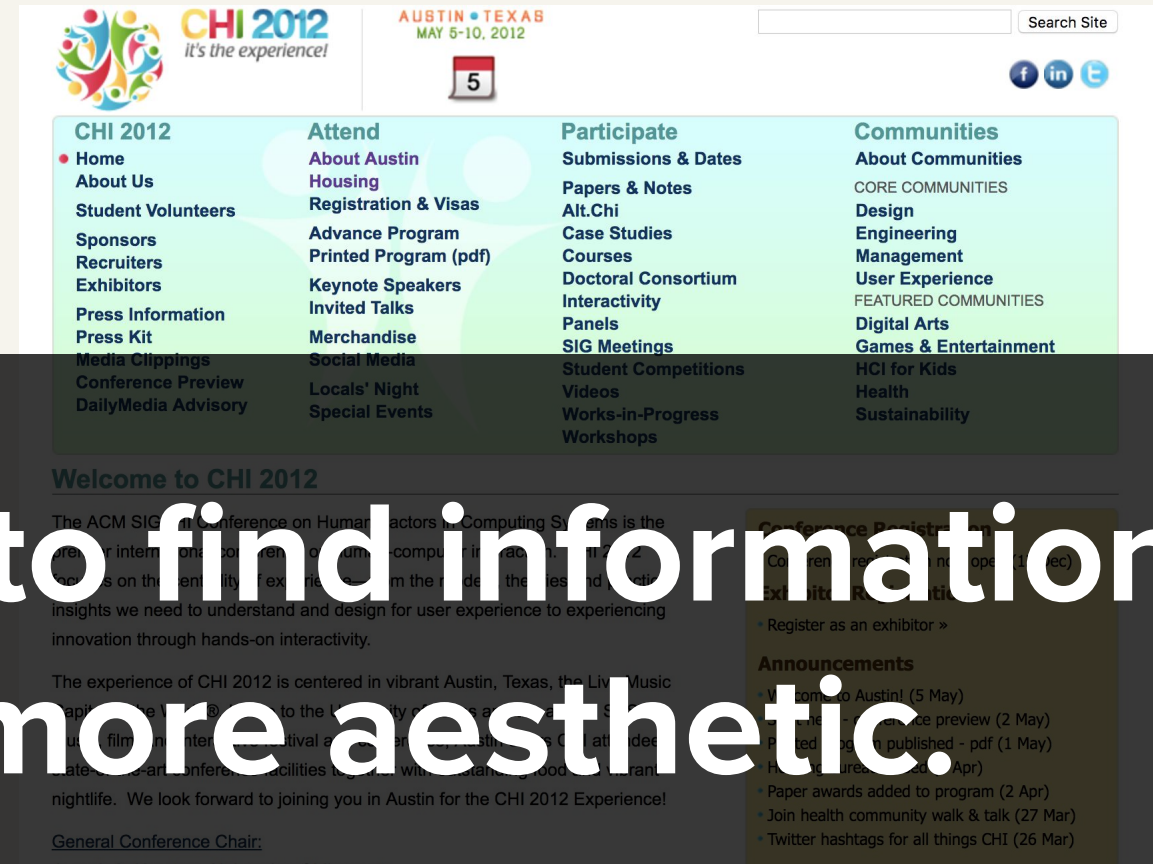
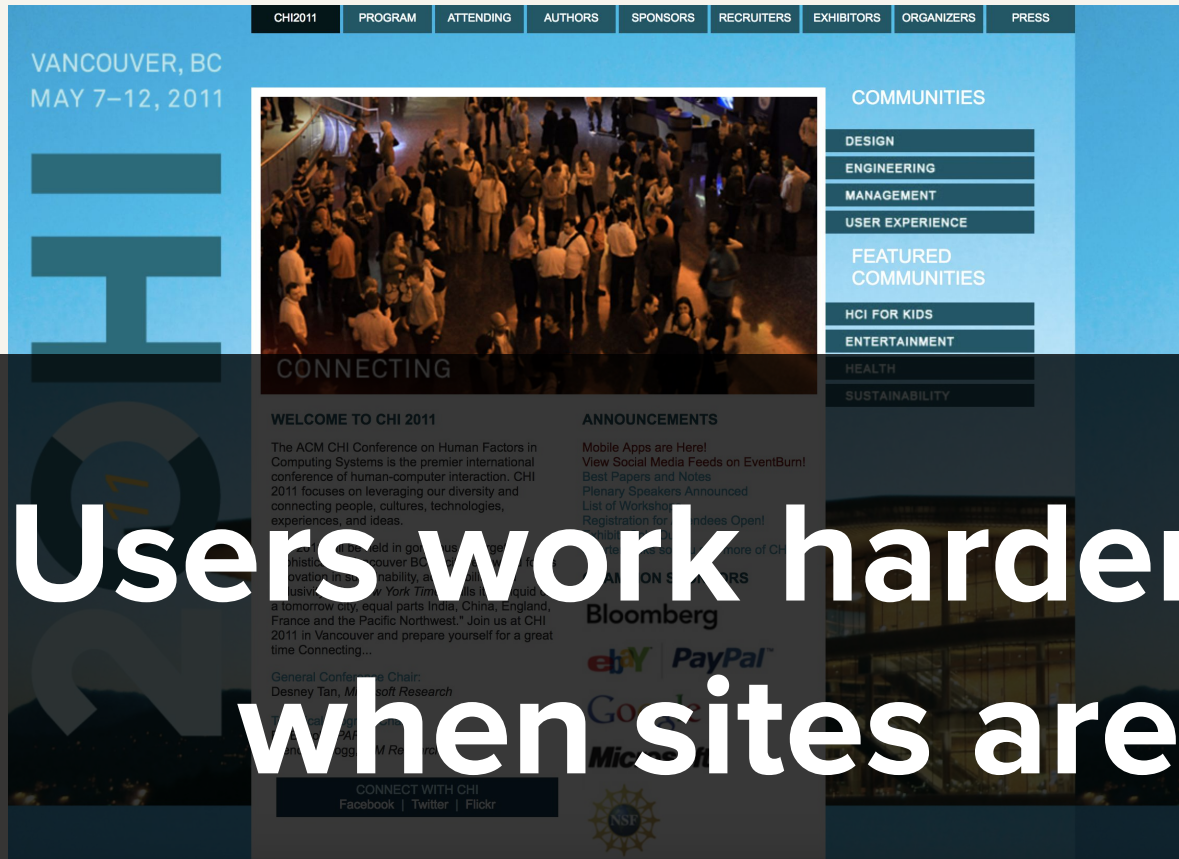
CHI 2012 Housing is open! [Make your housing reservation.](#)

Location

CHI 2012 is being held at the Austin Convention Center in downtown Austin, near



Aesthetics matter to finding information



Users work harder to find information when sites are more aesthetic.

COMS 4170 · SPRING 2026

Summary



The main feature of many websites is to display information in a way that helps users accomplish a goal.

```
i:Exit --PrevPg <Space>NextPg v:View Attachm. d:Del r:Reply j:Next ? :Help
624 Aug 03 T Martinez ( 37) Loans with tiny points are here now
625 0 Jul 01 R. Jackson ( 123) Loans with tiny rates are here now
626 Aug 05 Benjamin E. Mag ( 50) Long time no hear
627 May 17 Krista Aaron ( 44) long time no see....
628 0 Jun 03 Josiah House ( 35) Looking for a hot date tonight, tomorrow, or next week?
629 Jul 03 Brigitte I. Hay ( 63) Looking for a N.ew H.ome?
630 May 17 Joe Burns ( 58) Looking for you
631 Jun 01 Save in a poor ( 145) Low Rate Consolidation Mortgage Loan
632 + Jul 02 Igiel@virtualig ( 2) LowCost SoftWare OnCD
--Mutt: Mail/junk/spam [Msgs:950 Old:142 10M]--(subject/date)----- (66%)
Date: Mon, 17 May 2004 03:40:09 +0100
From: Krista Aaron <Christinefeminine@highstream.com>
Subject: long time no see....

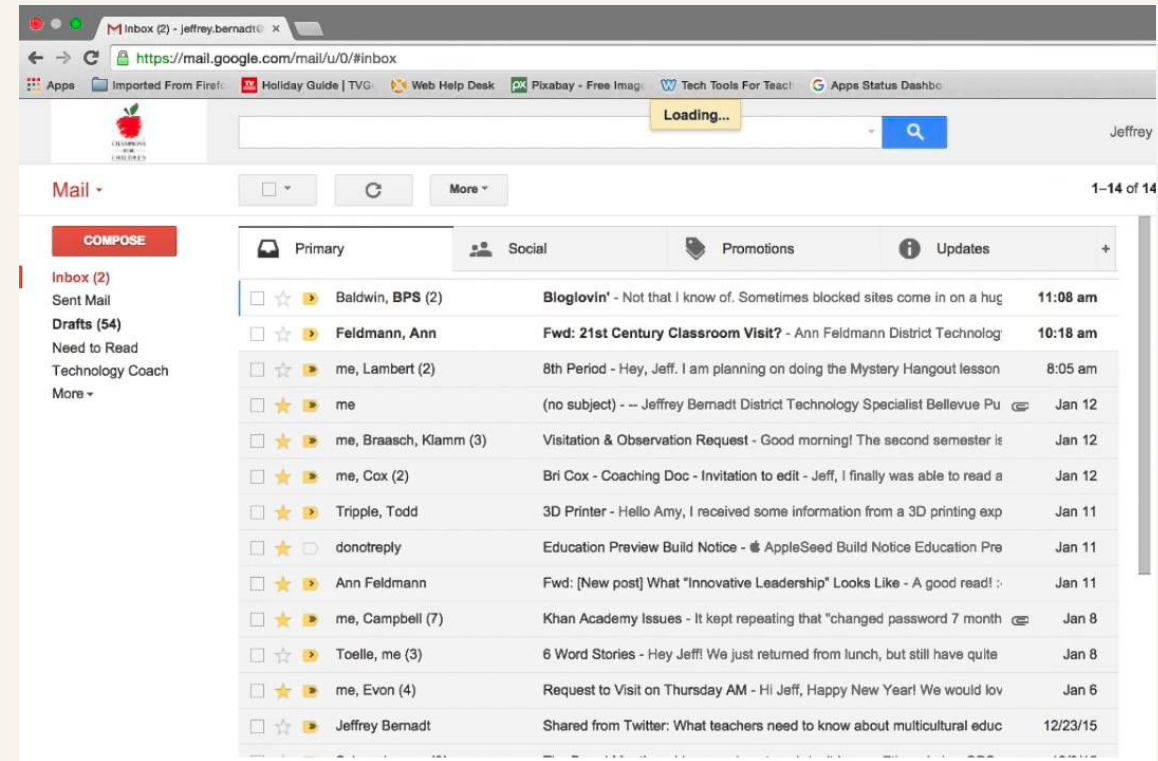
[-- Autoview using /usr/bin/links -force-html -dump '/tmp/mutt.html' --]
My name is Jen and I'm new to this dating thing. I've checked out your profile
you put up and it's interesting. => I just want to get to know you a little
better if you don't mind, come check my profile out at:

www.livejen.com/chat.html

I also got a webcam so we can make it interesting. anyways hope you get back to
me.
bye :)

gxsnkxxgnduvyjjwceudc.jobxs
zcocccrociessbehgbpow
rnxlfu.jnqpbliipdkgwuyqofracsz
xmqaubxsbjrppeibvlpfhqowldtp
bixhghvrtqgfeocofzyzb
hugzffaffulsklpzhrfxbtt
btpztlfotqmmoaawlosqv
-- 627/950: Krista Aaron long time no see.... -- (69%)
Key is not bound. Press '?' for help.
```

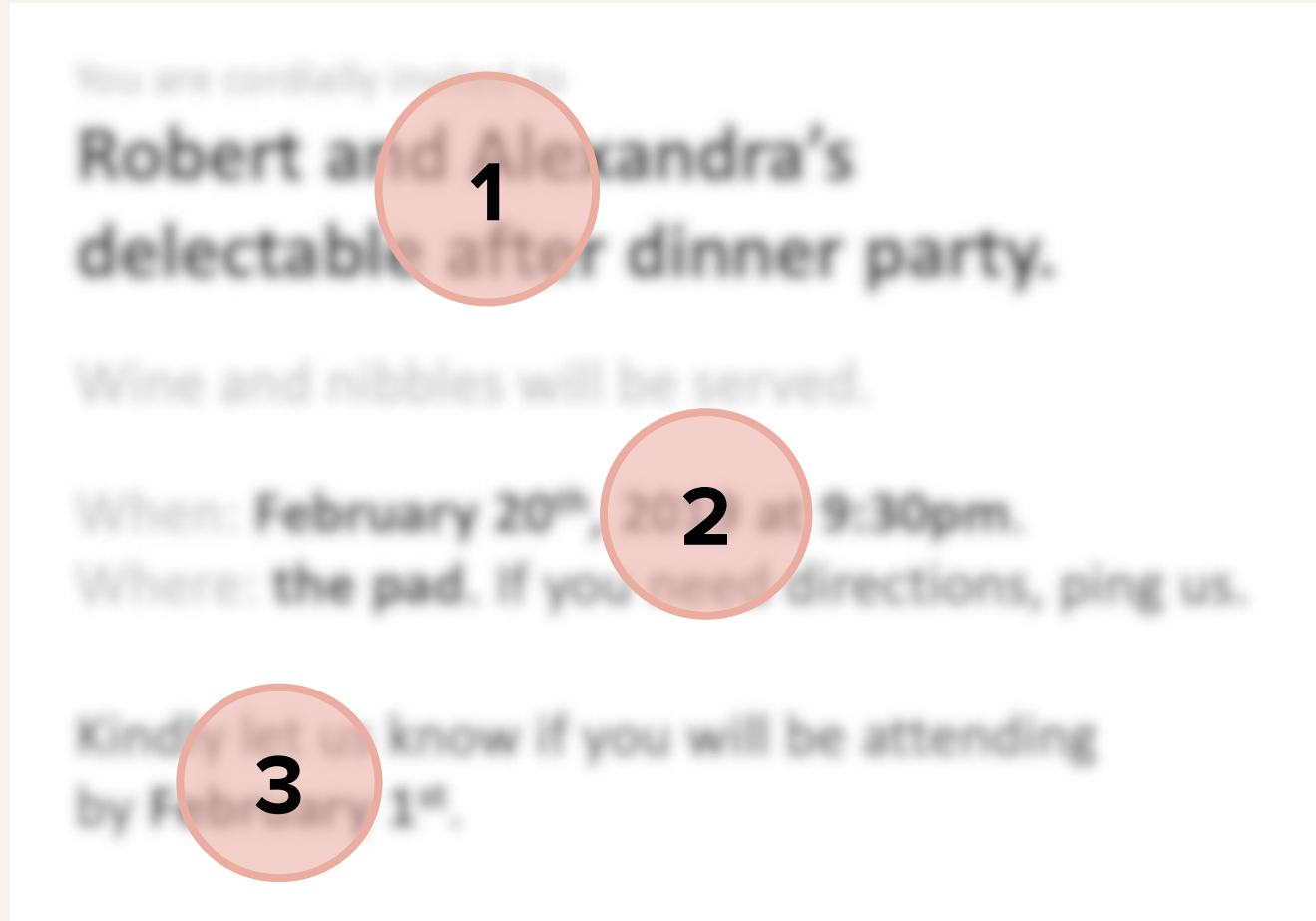
Pine text-based email client, 1989



GMail browser-based email service, 2004



Users have a spotlight of attention. Designers use a visual information hierarchy to guide users' attention.



Seven tools for visually indicating importance



You are cordially invited to
Robert and Alexandra's delectable after dinner
party.

Wine and nibbles will be served.

When: February 20th, 2018 at 9:30pm.
Where: the pad. If you need directions, ping us.

Kindly let us know if you will be attending by
February 1st.

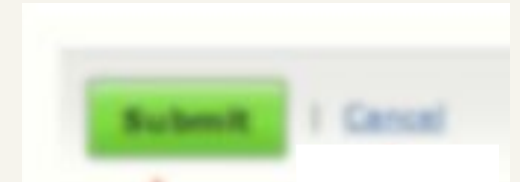
**Conceptual
grouping**



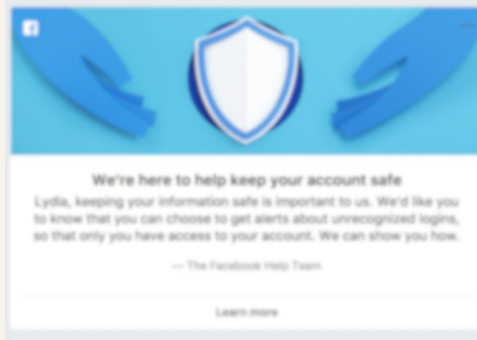
Location



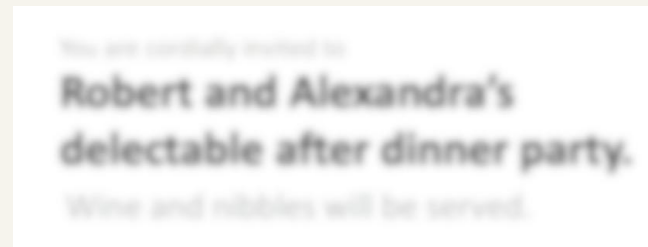
Whitespace



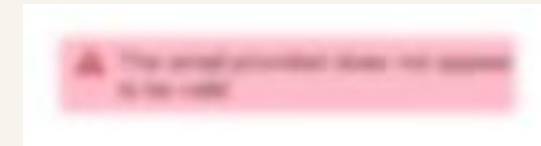
Size



Images



Contrast



Color



Use multiple tools. Use color last. Use size, whitespace and contrast instead.



You are cordially invited to Robert and Alexandra's delectable after dinner party. Wine and nibbles will be served. When: February 20th, 2019 at 9:30pm. Where: the pad. If you need directions, ping us. Kindly let us know if you will be attending by February 1st.

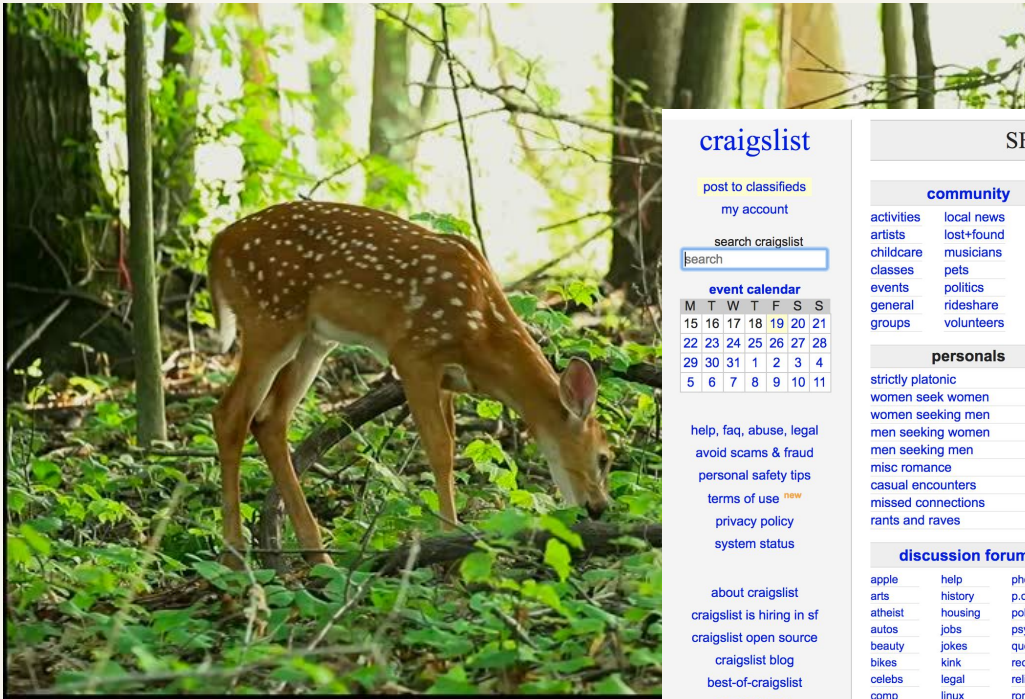
You are cordially invited to
**Robert and Alexandra's
delectable after dinner party.**
Wine and nibbles will be served.

When: **February 20th, 2019 at 9:30pm.**
Where: **the pad.** If you need directions, ping us.

Kindly let us know if you will be attending
by **February 1st.**



Information Foraging Theory says users follow visual or textual clues to sense if they are on the right track.



craigslist

post to classifieds
my account

search craigslist
search

event calendar

M	T	W	T	F	S	S
15	16	17	18	19	20	21
22	23	24	25	26	27	28
29	30	31	1	2	3	4
5	6	7	8	9	10	11

help, faq, abuse, legal
avoid scams & fraud
personal safety tips
terms of use new
privacy policy
system status

about craigslist
craigslist is hiring in sf
craigslist open source
craigslist blog
best-of-craigslist
craigslist TV
"craigslist joe"
craig connects
progressive directory
weather quake tide

community

activities
artists
childcare
classes
events
general
groups

local news
lost+found
musicians
pets
politics
rideshare
volunteers

personals

strictly platonic
women seek women
women seeking men
men seeking women
men seeking men
misc romance
casual encounters
missed connections
rants and raves

discussion forums

apple	help	photo
arts	history	p.o.c.
atheist	housing	politics
autos	jobs	psych
beauty	jokes	queer
bikes	kink	recover
celebs	legal	religion
comp	linux	romance
crafts	m4m	science
diet	manners	spirit
divorce	marriage	sports
dying	media	tax
eco	money	travel
educ	motocv	tv
feedback	music	vegan
film	nonprofit	w4w
fitness	open	wed
fixit	outdoor	wine
food	over 50	women
frugal	parent	words

SF bay area sfc aby eby pen nby scz

community

activities
artists
childcare
classes
events
general
groups

local news
lost+found
musicians
pets
politics
rideshare
volunteers

personals

strictly platonic
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women seeking men
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men seeking men
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casual encounters
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discussion forums

apple
arts
atheist
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beauty
bikes
celebs
comp
crafts
diet
divorce
dying
eco
educ
feedback
film
fitness
fixit
food
frugal

help
history
housing
jobs
jokes
kink
legal
linux
m4m
manners
marriage
media
money
motocv
music
nonprofit
open
outdoor
over 50
parent

photo
p.o.c.
politics
psych
queer
recover
religion
romance
science
spirit
sports
tax
travel
tv
vegan
w4w
wed
wine
women
words

housing

apts / housing
housing swap
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real estate for sale
rooms / shared
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sublets / temporary
vacation rentals

for sale

antiques
appliances
arts+crafts
atv/utv/sno
auto parts
baby+kid
barter
beauty+hlth
bikes
boats
books
business
cars+trucks
cds/dvd/vhs
cell phones
clothes+acc
collectibles
computers
electronics
farm+garden

free
furniture
garage sale
general
heavy equip
household
jewelry
materials
motorcycles
music instr
photo+video
rvs+camp
sporting
tickets
tools
toys+games
trailers
video gaming
wanted

services

automotive
beauty
cell/mobile
computer
creative

legal
lessons
marine
pet
real estate

jobs

accounting+finance
admin / office
arch / engineering
art / media / design
biotech / science
business / mgmt
customer service
education
food / bev / hosp
general labor
government
human resources
internet engineers
legal / paralegal
manufacturing
marketing / pr / ad
medical / health
nonprofit sector
real estate
retail / wholesale
sales / biz dev
salon / spa / fitness
security
skilled trade / craft
software / qa / dba
systems / network
technical support
transport
tv / film / video
web / info design
writing / editing
[ETC]
[part-time]

gigs

computer
creative
crew
domestic

event
labor
talent
writing

nearby ci

bakersfield
chico
fresno
gold country
hanford
humboldt
inland empire
klamath falls
las vegas
los angeles
medford
mendocino co
merced
modesto
monterey
orange co
palm springs
redding
reno
roseburg
sacramento
san luis obispo
santa barbara
santa maria
siskiyou co
stockton
susanville
ventura
visalia-tulare
yuba-sutter

us cities

us states

canada

ci worldwide

- Conceptual groupings
- Simple text labels
- Familiar Icons
- Aesthetic Design



Lecture 01: 10 Usability Heuristics

Homework 01



Homework 01

Warm Up due **Friday at 11:59PM**

- You can complete this now

Main Assignment due **Monday at 11:59PM**

- You will need Tuesday's lecture

Homework is posted to Courseworks:

<https://courseworks2.columbia.edu/courses/237745>



